Well met by Moonlight

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Mature

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), OC - Character

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by dzmatron

Summary

A shore. Vampires and Faeries.

A distant war.

A first meeting.

Notes

Something that came to me - a scene I had in my head for the longest time.

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

The horse's breath was visible in the chill of the night air , but the cold wasn't noticeable. Her fur kept the heat in, along with the layered cloak she wore;also, her kind ran hot much of the time - a side ef fect of their *condition* .

It was silent out - no birdsong, or the rustle of animals in the underbrush. The only real sound was the lapping of waves at the water's edge. The horses' hooves crunched on the pebbled shore as the animals jittered, restless. Idly, she pulled at the reigns to keep her mount steady as it tossed its head in boredom.

There was plenty of light - the moon wasn't full but it was certainly approaching it, and the water was a silvered colour from the reflected light. Of course, she didn't *need* much light to see. Even in their base state, her kind were nocturnal predators. Their circumstances had only enhanced that. Her vision was hampered by the faint mist that lay out a fair bit above the water. But to either side the beach was clear, the forest at their back a well defined line of monochrome trees.

Her mother said her eyes marked her for greatness - they were always the first thing *anyone* noticed. Eyes were, of course, important: windows to the soul. And hers - one honey-amber, the other ocean-blue, marked her as a bridge, a balance between the impetuosity of her race and the coolness of her station.

And of course, the eyes were the gate to your soul- *mate.* Everyone dreamt of the eyes of their to-be-partner. Nothing else, which she'd always found mildly frustrating. After all, dreaming of brown eyes? Green eyes? *W*ow, not like they weren't common!May as well dream *you will fall in love with a PERSON* for how non-specific it felt.

Not that she had dreamt all that much, admittedly. Not until recently, as she came of age. Another laughable concept - considering she

was likely to be alive a *long* time now.

She turned her mismatched gaze on her companions - her honour guard. Dark, overlapping folds of lamellar armour , myriad daggers sheathed across buckles and silver-tipped lances held upright. Their helms altered to allow their ears to protrude. Not like the unsightly domes the humans wore - all iron and ugliness. Magicats preferred more flexible approaches. After all, if you got hit *at all* then you were pretty much done for. Better to go for something light, flexible and able to deflect a glancing blow.

For her own part, she'd gone for something more formal - she eschewed *dresses* . Few of the women of Halfmoon thought them useful - they got in the way of one's tail after all. Oh some wore them, for occasions, or ceremonies. But they left the billowing cloth to the *faeries* or their human allies.

The thought made her adjust the bracers of her own more formal set of armour and she let a low growl rumble up from her throat. The hunger was creeping up on her again.

She'd fed a few hours prior , on one of the supplicant serfs in a village they'd passed through. The woman had been compensated with a bag of grain, to cover the loss of labour she would suffer, being left anaemic for a few days. But still, the hunger was strong. Likely the moon. It was such a weight upon all of their kind, but particularly those with her condition.

"You are impatient," the voice was surly , a drawl. It only *just* skirted being a sneer, "I thought I taught you better , Catra."

Catra pursed her lips and flicked her wrist at a guard, who yanked on a thin iron chain clasped in his fist. There was a grunt of protest and a hiss of anger. Laughter rippled through the gathered guards and Catra turned a smirk to the figure between her and the guard. This one *wasn't* mounted. She had lost that privilege after attempting to kidnap Catra as a kitten. Lucky for her, Queen Cyra had an ironic sense of humour. Mildly less lucky for Catra, but there was also a

lesson for the young Princess in this as well - learn from your enemies. Keep them close. Learn to *control* them where you can.

"Why , Weaver, you talk as if I asked your opinion," Catra drawled. She smirked at the rag-clad figure. Robes that may, once, have been red, but were now a faded scarlet. A cracked mask that revealed the scarring beneath. "But your ability to read the room is, as ever , utterly *fucking* useless."

Weaver. A once-trusted advisor. A mage of repute. And a consummate liar, manipulator and ambitious traitor.

She was, also, proud as anything and tended to severely underestimate her opponents. Such as Catra's mother. Never try to cross a cat.

And never try to cross a *vampire* cat.

The woman had tried to steal Catra when she was a mere four solstices old. And she'd paid dearly for it. First, with Catra scarring her face (Magicat kittens were *far* from defenceless; couple that with her *other* nature and, well... the woman was *messed up*); then second when Cyra had practically apparated into the room and proceed to vent her rather substantial rage at the woman.

She'd spent the next few years in the dungeons, then had been made Catra's *tutor* when the girl turned nine. That had been a very interesting time - never left alone with the girl; but Catra had been expected to listen, to learn. But also to observe, to understand that Weaver would try to manipulate, convince and cajole her into actions; or attempt to be downright *abusive* where she could.

Everything was a lesson. *Everything* . That was the truth of Halfmoon. The truth of the Magicats. And even more so in those who suffered the affliction of vampirism within their subterranean city.

After all, your civilisation didn't survive without learning a few tricks.

"My lady , why have we brought this…thing with us?" the captain of her guard, Pan, muttered. He sat astride a black charger to her other side. She transferred her smirk to him.

"She' s versed in Horde tactics, even after all this time. And we can always use her as a distraction should the faeries attempt a double cross."

The captain smirked, "Devious. Y our mother would approve."

"Oh I know ," Catra studied her claws, then rested her hands on the pommel of her saddle, "Plus she could do with the exercise."

"Still, she is a sorceress"…

"A fairly useless one, without her gems and bound by runed iron," Catra shrugged, "Do you doubt the capabilities of your men, should she break loose?"

Pan chuckled, "Hardly . I just might mess my mane is all."

Catra cackled, "The amount of oil in there? More chance of it catching aflame."

Another chuckled rippled along the line of soldiers. Weaver huffed and looked back up at Catra, "Y ou forget my lessons, child. You are in the open, vulnerable, lax. Y ou face an unknown foe."

The soldiers fell silent and watched their princess. Catra frowned and looked down at the bound woman, then cocked her head, then shook it, "All so black and white with you, W eaver. No *nuance* . Wheels within wheels, I know. We *could* dig an entrenched position, but that'd rather defeat the *point* of this whole parley, now, wouldn't it?"

"My lady ," Pan leaned forward and gestured to the sky . He, like her, shared the affliction of Vampirism. Most who shared the noble blood of Halfmoon did, after all; the price paid to save their people. As

such, his eyesight and senses were enhanced beyond the normal (already pretty exceptional) abilities of a magicat. She followed his gaze and pursed her lips.

"Show of fs."

The faerie contingent had arrived. They fluttered over the trees further along the beach, to descend to the pebbled surface a few hundred yards away. Catra rolled her eyes as a flash of pink light announced the arrival of *another* faerie a moment later. Pan glanced sideways at her. But it was Weaver who spoke, surprise in her voice.

"They have their *princess* here?"

"Why so shocked? I'm here," Catra deadpanned.

"I meant to say…Their princess is not as…Hardened as you," Catra leaned over her from her saddle and spoke with an amused lilt to her voice.

"W as…was that a *compliment* Weaver? W ow, what *effort* . You've clearly got an angle. Anyway that means the faeries are serious about this, if Glitter's here."

"Glimmer ," deadpanned Pan. Catra waved a hand.

"Eh, Ill get it right to her face."

Weaver pushed herself up and huffed again, "Y ou still cannot be sure this *isn't* a trap. They have sent their most potent magic user. Even if she is *not* as experienced as you. And this third…faction."

Catra's smirk shifted to a frown, "Y ou almost sound like you *care* ."

"I care, Catra, because you or your mother will *kill* me if I do not make a good showing. But having two of the heirs to the most powerful nations on the continent? This meeting is…a lot more dangerous. And, well, this other faction? How can we be sure? Catra, they are *reavers* . The faeries could have set this up to

undermine you, to capture you, coerce Halfmoon to assist," the woman's voice is acid and it turned Catra's frown back into a smirk.

"Your… *Concern* is noted, Weaver. And maybe. But that's *risky;* we could kill their Princess, *take her,* turn *her,"* she waved a hand airily, "Anyway, that's what *you're* here for. Be all… magically aware, spot if they're pulling some weird stuff."

Weaver shifted and her ragged clothing rustled against the rocky beach, "I am hardly at my most *effective* with these shackles."

Catra shook her head, "That was a pretty lame attempt, by your standards. No, we just need you to keep an eye out."

Weaver tilted her head back, showing some of the scars on her neck, "And, as ever… if I refuse?"

"Hot irons, the hole, the rack… I mean we *could* do that… but d'ya think the Brightmooners are going to be all nice to a former Horde necromancer? Nah, you could *try* something. Hope they'll be merciful. But we *know* your history with them. So, yeah… You're gonna help. Again. And you'll keep helping until we decide we can *finally* cut you loose. So, play nice."

Weaver's teeth were almost audible as she ground them together. Fifteen years captivity, most of it with fairly *liberal* freedom and she still groused. Well, she went about the place with a guard, shackled and with few freedoms, save when she was permitted to tend her garden. But still - she was at least *alive*.

Catra turned her focus back on the troupe of faeries - all silver cloaks and silver armour and silver weapons. Frankly, it was a bit *dull*. The metal wasn't silver; wasn't even really metal, just some materials that had the same consistency when *magic'd*. Catra wasn't all that familiar with the means - magicats had inherent magic, but few *mages*. And as a vampire, her skills were yet *more* innate. She'd never expressed a talent for wielding magic.

The honour guard, their gossamer wings concealed beneath their cloaks, took up station, facing the waves, lined up with the magicats. The Princess, however, strode over the gravelly beach, a solitary companion with her. Catra snorted as she saw the girl stumble on an awkward piece of rock.

"Dammit, moon curse this whole damn beach to fucking Sheol!"

"Wow, Glim, what would your mom think?" purred Catra. The diminutive figure paused and Catra could make out the girl's glower in the darkness.

"Oh, great. It's *you*."

"Well *duh*. I was gonna be all formal, guess you can't extend the courtesy, Sparkles?" the magicat soldiers laughed, their horses shying slightly as Catra moved her own forwards, "Lord Bow," Ctara's tone shifted from sarcastic to actually pleasant, "Good to see you. How's the arm?"

The second figure, a human, grinned in the dark. His dark skin was paradoxically luminescent in the moonlight, ethereal, "Princess Catra, glad to see you're still as quick. And it's healing well. My thanks for the salve."

"Eh, don't mention it. The druids are... Good at that shit."

"And she says I've got a mouth," grumbled the faerie princess. She was relatively petite, curvy, with shimmering pink hair. Her companion draped an arm over her shoulder and squeezed.

"My love... we're here for a *reason*."

"Yes, do *tell* why we should trust you," came Weavers acid tones. She stepped forwards, but then staggered back as her attendant guard hauled on the chain. Glimmer's expression darkened.

"Why is *that* here?"

Catra sighed and shrugged, "Honestly? Insurance. And, yknow, bait. On the off chance you tried something, or these mysterious new allies of yours try something."

Glimmer snorted, "Tsch, paranoid or what?"

"My entire civilisation lives under a mountain because your people sicked *giants* on us."

"That was two thousand years ago!"

"Yeah. My grandma was *there*. So was *your mom*," deadpanned Catra. Bow winced and looked between the pair.

"Um, speaking as the sole mortal rep here... I feel a bit left out."

The two Princesses regarded him, then broke down into giggles. Catra shook her head and straightened in the saddle, then regarded Glimmer, "Alright. I guess I can admit I doubt *you* would pull a trick like that, Glim. BUT your court is *full* of people who might. We aren't... Popular."

"UGH! Your people used *dark magic*..." Glimmer harrumphed, then sighed, "Sort of. And I can't exactly blame you. It was a bad time."

"We are in worse ones now. Your little political spats are as nothing to the devouring Horde," intoned Weaver. Bow looked between the women.

"Does she... need, like a thunderstorm or something? She sounds like she's trying for ominous."

"Honestly, I thought she'd stop doing that after a few years, but nope... apparently it's a *thing* for her," drawled Catra. She studied her claws, then peered out into the mists. Next to her, Weaver stiffened. Glimmer turned as well, to look out to sea.

"No..no no no," W eaver's voice was a whimper now. She scrabbled her manacles, then turned and ran. Except the chain stopped her and she slid onto her ass, "They'll *kill us all* ."

Catra stared at the witch, then looked at Glimmer sharply. The faerie looked perplexed. Her features were clear to Catra and she watched Bow's face settle into an equally confused frown. She chewed her lip, then spoke. Behind her, she could feel her guard tensing up, "Glim, spill. All my mom got was that your people had been… contracting some mercenaries? Helping with the Horde on the Wastes boundaries?"

Glimmer nodded, "Y eah. They're..they're a bit strange. But they're good fighters. Powerful. They've traded with the human kingdoms a fair bit, in Salineas and the Nordland."

"And..why?"

"Why?"

"Why did you want to get *us* to meet them?"

Glimmer frowned and shook her head, "They wanted to meet *you*. Your people. I mean, you guys aren't exactly..well known. They're explorers, they say ."

Catra pointed lazily at W eaver, "Explorers that can break a Horde necromancer in a few seconds?"

Bow pursed his lips, "I'll admit that's..weird."

Catra turned in the saddle and nodded to Pan, "Reel her back, get the horses to the tree line, far enough for a charge down the beach, just in case. Ready the archers."

"By your command, Princess."

She turned back to Glimmer who now looked unsure, "T raders? And mercenaries?"

"They..they wanted to of fer their services they said."

"Or it could be a trap for *me*," mused Catra. Honestly , the prospect of a fight ex ited her a little. Horde minions weren't much of a challenge, being shambling corpses, or strange, stitched together monsters. But they were no match for her boosted metabolism.

Glimmer shook her head, "They wanted to meet a representative… They don't even know about…What you *are* . You mom sent *you* ," the faerie frowned, "D..do you think maybe *she* knows?"

"Does your mom?"

Glimmer shrugged, then gestured for her troops to fall back, "I've met..one of them. And she seemed pretty nice. I mean, not going to lie, terrifying. But…weirdly enthusiastic."

"This is you saying that, as well. I mean, you define *overshare* to a level beyond, Sparkles," growled Catra, but there wasn't much bite to her words. Bow snorted. Glimmer shot him a look.

"If we weren't married, I'd sock you one."

Bow held his hands up, then unhooked the bow from his shoulder, "My love, don't lie. Y ou just want to damage my amaz ng face. Or have me sleep in the ante room."

Glimmer huffed, then looked at Catra, "T rust me, Catra. Please?"

Catra studied Glimmer, then shrugged, "Uh. I mean you're a *pain* . But..well," they had history . Skirmishes, fighting, the usual spats between kingdoms with bad blood. But conflict brought diplomacy and they had an easy back and forth. At one stage, when they'd been younger, they had pondered the possibility of something else, but one afternoon of meeting and staring into each other's eyes had answered that - not the colours they saw. And the frisson had a charge that was more adversarial.

Also, Bow, as the Duke representing the human Coalition, and their ambassador in Brightmoon, had swept Glimmer away that same day. And it had come as a relief to Catra. She wasnt sure why .

The slosh of water caught their attention, at odds to the waves. There was the creak of something in the mist, then a cry rang out from the sea:

“ *Vooooo…. Naaaaaa.”*

The voice echoed about. Then it came again.

“Voooo… Naaaa.”

Closer now. The voice was a bellow, but had a soft lilt to it. Catra’s ears twitched to hear it. Her tail lashed behind her and she felt the hairs on her arm rise. Strange.

A ship came into view, as if the mist formed *into* it in the dark. The vessel pushed through the rolling tendrils, almost silent, the sculling oars slicing through waves with eerie precision. It was a shallow-hulled thing, with a prow shaped like some sort of beast. A single mast stood amidships. The trio watched as the vessel closed in towards shore. They heard the scrape of hull against stone as the vessel beached itself. It was still mostly in the water and Catra watched as the crew hauled their oars in.

A strange bunch - woollen-looking clothing, what looked like metal helms. The angle of the boat made them difficult to see as most were still hunched over their oars.

And then a figure swung off the back of the boat and splashed into the sea foam.

Catra was taken aback. The figure was tall, broad of shoulder, yet not *gargantuan* . They wore what looked like white cloth, bound at the waist with a bronze belt. A furred cloak was about their

shoulders, the lining bunched about the figure's neck. It looked like the hide of some great, red beast.

Catra watched as the figure waded towards the shore, cloak dragging in the waves behind them. Closer now, Catra realised it was a woman. Her hair was almost white in the light of the moon, done into a high ponytail. Her face was framed by a helm that looked more ornate than anything, similar to the stylised crown that Catra's mother wore;which in itself was *strange* .

The woman's armour was minimal - the white cloth seemed to be a tabard of sorts over a woolen tunic and white pants. Her arms were bare, save for a set of bracers;her legs had a set of bronzed greaves. As she drew nearer details became clearer and Catra noted the pommel of some great blade was visible, strapped to the woman's back.

Catra's horse whickered and stepped backwards;its feet pranced against the pebbles uncertainly.

The woman emerged from the surf and cocked her head, then tilted her head to grin towards Glimmer, "Your *majesty* ."

The words weren't mocking, per se, but there was a hint of amusement to them. Glimmer snorted, "Yeah, right. You're one to talk."

Catra watched the woman carefully. She seemed at ease, no hostile air to her at all. As if she had not a care in the world. She tore her gaze from the strange figure and blinked. The ship's crew were arrayed on the beach *already* . Their clothing was likewise basic - what looked like some sort of padded armour, bracers and so forth. But they carried a variety of shields and axes, their helms a strange mixture of styles, most obscuring the faces.

Her name drew her gaze back to the other three and she arched an eyebrow. Glimmer rolled her eyes, "As I was saying...this is Catra of Halfmoon."

Ah. Glimmer hadnt said she was a Princess. That was oddly considerate - letting Catra gauge things herself. She studied the woman and smirked, "A pleasure."

The blonde regarded her and then flicked her eyes up to meet Catra's.

The magicat's breath caught. Her heart stuttered.

Blue eyes stared at her from her dreams. The blonde's expression also seemed to twitch ever so faintly. Catra thought she saw the girl's nose twitch. Much like Catra's did when she caught a scent.

And the girl's scent hit her like the bolt of a crossbow.

Salt, sea and body;planed wood;oils, weapon cleaning;a strange, musky smell, primal almost;a faint, lingering sense of *perfume*?

She blinked as she saw the blonde turn to fully face her. The woman *looked* gigantic, but was probably only a foot or so taller than Catra. If that. But she had presence. The blonde smiled and it was, perhaps the most open expression Catra had *ever* seen on a person.

"A pleasure, Catra. As these two have *clearly* been remiss. I am Adora Moondaughter, Third of that name, of the Clan Grayskull. And we are at your service."

Catra stared at the woman, then blinked again. Her words failed. Her mind was a mess of confused scents, half formed dreams. She felt *very* off balance. But she was a Princess. A warrior. Unmatched in the games of court and the blade. With a roll of her shoulders, she straightened, and opened her mouth to speak.

"Hey , Adora"…

Hearth and Home

Chapter Summary

A continuance.

The strangers are good hosts.

And they know more than they let on.

Chapter Notes

CW // something approaching flirtation with blood.

And yes, have another chapter of this. I hope the continuation is WORTHY.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The strange sea-goers moved with a speed clearly practiced. Catra was impressed - her people had a port, hidden in a cavern. It was a thing of canals and managed waterways, the magicats not a sea-faring people as a rule.

The way these people had the boat hauled onto shore in mere moments *and* had what looked like an effective guard in place already was astounding. The blonde hadnt lost her grin and was clearly studying Catra, but she paused to turn to her crew and gestured to a broad man in a flat-topped helmet.

"Duncan! Secure the boat, and get the supplies of floaded," then she looked back to Catra. Her gaze flicked to the woodline and her grin turned into a laugh, "And Catra, you may stand your honour guard down. We come with no axe in hand."

Catra arched an eyebrow and her horse whickered again. That was very strange - it was very agitated. She pushed her heels into the

beasts flank and twitched the reins once more, then looked at Adora, "Well, some waterlogged sailors staggering up the beach. It *could* be an attempt to lull us into a false sense of security."

Adora still looked amused, "True. But what would be the goal? We come to talk. And I would like to dry my clothes a little. The trees, thick is the forest?"

Her manner of speaking was a little stilted, but the question seemed honest, "Not enough to stop horses."

"But good enough for firewood?"

"I suppose," Catra wasn't exactly a camping *expert*. She had soldiers and logisticians for that. Adora just nodded, then looked back to her people.

"Teela, take the men, fell logs. We prepare a pit!"

The crew all let out a strange *whoop* and axes rattled on shields. Glimmer sighed and shook her head, then looked at Catra, "Great. Party time."

Catra looked at the faerie, confused, "Uh.what?" she was wrongfooted. Adora planted her hands on her hips, which did amazing things for her whole profile.

"Never talk terms on an empty stomach. We've been eating salted fish and meat for days, a chance for drink and *roasted* food"… Adora's head tipped back, "So good! So, please. We will prepare the pit, then we can talk? Or do you wish for sun up?"

The way the question was phrased with an arched eyebrow and a half smirk sent warning bells through Catra's head. Her eyes narrowed at the blonde warrior and she cocked her head, "You want to work fast. Surely you need to rest, recuperate?"

Adora shrugged, "T ime is wasting, the moon is up and we are invigorated. Come, come, let us talk..but save the pressing concerns until our bellies are full, no?"

The faerie Princess sighed, "Better to just agree, Catra. She' s hungry. She doesnt do anything until she' s been fed."The faerie walked with Adora, the silver-clad Brightmoon troops heading along the same line towards the trees.

"Hardly true!"scof fed the blonde, "I do some things."

"Dnking does *not* count."

"It certainly does,"the blonde strode up the beach, whilst her crew hauled supplies off the ship - wood, barrels of food, a large cast-iron cauldron and what looked like bushels of arrows and rolled oils of weapons. Catra frowned, then realised Adora had passed her and was already halfway to the treeline.

The woman moved quickly , but was moving at an angle to the Halfmoon troops, not *at* them - clearly not wishing to appear threatening.

Catra kicked her horse into a trot and headed for her lines. Pan met her and frowned at the newcomers, "Who are they?"

"Not a clue. They just look like vagabonds to me, but Glimmer has faith in them."

Pan snorted, "They look barely put together . A single volley of our arrows, or a cavalry charge and they'd be done for ."

Catra chuckled, "Probably . Let's humour them. It could be some great con that the Faeries have fallen for. And, well, I am *not* missing that. Get the men to the camp, stand down save the sentries. And bring Weaver..I wanna see what they make of her , if she's so jumpy around *them* . Oh and take Stal back with you..."she patted her horses neck, then slid from its back.

Pan nodded, then gathered Catra's reins and pushed his horse to a trot, barking commands to the line of archers and horsemen. The magicat troops melted back into the forest, to a small clump of tents a hundred yards into the treeline, barely visible. Her people were masters of camouflage and stealth, but the reality of any large troop movement, even only a couple of dozen soldiers, was still hard to completely obscure.

She headed after Glimmer, Bow and Adora on foot, easily catching up. The blonde had moved into the treeline and was now watching as the one called Teela and several others cleared a patch of smaller trees. Catra stared as the strange sea-folk hacked at trees with broad axes and felled them in short order . Teela made swift work at stripping away branches and then *split* a log with her bare hands.

Catra was strong, stronger than a human, but a fresh log snapped like that?

There was definitely more to these people.

Glimmer shot her an excited smile and Catra folded her arms to watch while Bow chatted to Adora. The magicat turned one ear to listen in.

"So, um, how was the voyage? And your homeland?"

"At peace, finally . Adam is ruling now. He has earned the respite, though I know he is missing a certain *someone* ."

Teela scoffed across the clearing, but Catra noted her blush. The red head paused as she hauled a log into place, then hefted it to stand on its end. Again, the *strength* was impressive. Teela sent a glower at Adora then huffed, "Well one of us has to keep an eye on you!"

"I think you find me less interesting to watch than Adam..."

"He is less prone to staggering into chaos."

"And yet he picked you as his mate!"

Teela leaned back and laughed, "W e are all entitled to fortuitous chance, are we not?"

Adora snorted and shook her head, but Bow cut in, "So, you have no war there? No...invasion?"

The blonde shrugged, "Conflict is everywhere. Clan wars, rites of succession. But we have no *invasion* , no. We have...handled it. Just as we will handle yours. In time. Provided your friend who is listening in is amenable."

Catra blinked as Adora turned to grin at her. The magicat Princess arched an eyebrow and twitched her ear. Adora winked and Catra felt something flutter in her belly, then watched as the tall woman moved to help her people.

That was surprising - she got stuck in, splitting logs, hauling logs and helping the others as they carried barrels and hide-tarpaulins up from the ship.

Slowly the camp came into form - a slightly dug out pit with a cone of logs arrayed in it, as tall as a man;that was then stuf fed with kindling and smaller split wood. Around the clearing, three smaller firepits were set up, with kettles and cauldrons atop them, while log seats were set up around the main fire. The blonde uncorked a flask from her belt and poured it into the large, central bonfire, then fished out some grains of powder from another pouch, which she tossed in also.

Adora then turned to one of the older looking sailors and took a flint from the man, then faced the fire. She smiled at Catra, Glimmer and Bow, "Since we have no hall, this will have to do. Y ou are welcome by our hearth. Let our fire warm you and keep the shadows at bay. Take salt and succour with us, leave your blades and banes at the threshold,"

And with that she struck the flint, which sent a spark into the pyre. It roared to life as the oil caught, then the powder popped and sparked white. The kindling baked and sputtered as sap boiled, whilst the cuts in the log bases blackened while the flames took hold. The heat washed off the pile like a wave and Catra shied back briefly.

The sea-folk all stood straight and tilted their heads back and let out a collective sigh, then mostly dispersed. It was strange, watching them suddenly go about their business, as if this was not some historic meeting. Adora closed her eyes and rolled her shoulders, then reached up and pulled the scabbard and greatsword over her shoulder, to prop it against the log next to her. Then she unclasped the cloak at her throat and tossed it down over a log, then sat and gestured for the others to sit.

Catra stepped over the log adjacent to Adora's, along with Glimmer and Bow. She noticed that all the other seafolk had paused as well and some had turned in the direction of her approaching guards. She noted the faeries appeared to be sticking to the edge of the woodline, just beyond the fire. That seemed smart - keep these strangers surrounded. Trust, but never too much.

The camp was silent, save for the clank of pots and the rustle of men and women unfurling their tarps and sheets - staves were set as tents were raised;others just unfurled mats onto the forest floor;a few simply strung twine between trees to setup little more than windbreaks. It all seemed haphazard.

Adora leaned back on her log and stretched her legs out. Catra couldnt help but let her eyes drag over the woman as steam rose of f Adora's damp form. They werent that close to the fire, but the heat was like a physical pressure. Catra fidgeted and looked at Glimmer, then leaned closer, "What' s the deal?"

The faerie huffed, "They're big on social stuf f."

"Who isnt?"

"No, it's...it's...s kinda spiritual to them I think," Glimmer frowned, "Hearth and home."

The magicat chuckled, "That is pretty damn obvious. So, are we going to talk or...lounge?"

"As I said, we've been at sea for a while...a chance to dry of f shouldn't be missed. Not always fun being damp," the blonde tilted her head and grinned at the trio on their log. She nodded and Catra turned. Teela approached from one of the other campfires with a leather flask which she proffered to Catra. The magicat frowned at the drink and sniffed it. Her nose wrinkled.

"What is this?"

Adora grinned, "Mead. Honey wine."

Catra shook her head, "Um...no, thank you."

Teela glanced at Adora who seemed to be mulling something over. She leaned forwards, "Do you *drink*, Catra?" Adora smiled knowingly at her.

The magicat frowned back, then smirked, "So, what, you were going to offer me some *fire water*, see if I can take it?"

Adora shrugged, "Just wondered if you liked sweet or salt. We have mead. Or wine. I am unsure what Half-moon's tastes are."

The blue eyes fixed on her and Catra felt she was being studied. She decided to probe the inquiry.

"Well, I haven't heard of *mead*. Our tastes vary, you know. Just...as a rule we don't do sweet."

"Hm," mused the blonde. She nodded at the campfires, "Will your people join us for food? Or are they amply provisioned? We have fish, fresh caught today. Or do you need something fresher?"

The chuckles from the other seafolk around the campfire had Catra's hackles up suddenly. She shot Glimmer a frown, then looked back at the blonde, whose smile was still in place. And it looked honest and open. But Catra still felt a little on guard. These people seemed genuine and Adora was pleasant enough, but their casual, slightly hinting commentary was a little concerning.

"I had something earlier ."

Adora, frowned, but nodded and then sat up as one of the other sailors presented her with a slab of bread with a dripping hunk of meat. Glimmer winced but Bow hummed appreciatively as they received his own hunk of flesh. The blonde glanced up as she tore a strip of meat from the chunk in front of her and then popped it into her mouth.

She seemed to consider something, then placed her food down. She stood and walked over to Catra. She studied the magicat for a moment, then smiled and knelt in front of her. She patted the dagger at her belt and then arched an eyebrow at the magicat, as if asking for permission.

Catra felt curious. She knew if Adora wanted to try something, to harm her, she would hardly be so blatant.The woman ahd been up front and pretty direct so far.

But these were unknown people. Sea reavers. And surprisingly strong. She frowned, "What do you want?"

"In my homeland, to refuse hospitality is an insult."

"We're in *our* homeland"…

"But in *my* camp. Under my protection,"Adora shrugged, "Salt and bread."

"Excuse me?"Catra's frown shifted to one of puzzlement. She knew other places had customs around guests or how many days you

could claim sanctuary. This was new.

"A sort of.. Oath," supplied Glimmer, "Sharing a meal, even a basic one, shows respect."

Adora gestured at Glimmer, "She gets it."

"Well, um... I guess I accept then," Catra frowned, "But, uh… Your mead wont taste like much to me."

"We have wine. Or like I said... fresher? May I?"

Catra nodded warily. Adora smirked, then unsheathed her dagger. The magicat noticed that the other seafolk had paused and were watching. Except they were watching *Catra* as much as Adora. She saw several had hands near weapons. Catra tensed herself and Adora paused.

The blonde turned her head and *growled*.

Actually *growled*.

It was a low sound and it sent a shiver through Catra's bones into the pit of her stomach. Her magicat body felt terror and the *flight* response. But her vampiric senses said something else.

Kin?

The other seafolk paused, but stayed attentive. An older one coughed, then spoke up, "Adora…"

"*Duncan*. We must show proper hospitality."

And then Adora pricked the tip of her finger with the blade. She met Catra's eyes, then proffered the tip of her finger. Adora wiped her blade on her pants then resheathed it, but didnt break eye contact. She reached up and squeezed the finger and blood pooled for the small wound.

Catra stared at the woman and *knew* that these people were far more aware of Halfmoon than anyone had realised. She swallowed as her eyes flickered around the clearing. All eyes were on her.

She could try to deny it, knock Adora's hand away in disgust, try to mask it. But then again the surrounding villages would likely tell-all. Or at least *enough* . The hamlets that were tithed to the city were aware, to a degree, of the nature of their masters.

The vampires of Halfmoon werent quite a secret;the location of their city (Or rather, the entrances) were. Their precise nature - how many magicats were afflicted, the nature of the curse and so on, all of that was myth and distraction, spread by the magicats themselves. Half of those rumours being intentionally exaggerated to make people actually scoff at the idea of *vampires* at all. And, of course, with the Horde, association with dark magic was always an unpleasant reality. The magicats kept Halfmoon secret and the rumours vague to *protect* themselves - to appear threatening, mysterious and inaccessible. And to ensure no one assumed they were part of the Horde.

So it wasnt beyond the realm of possibility that these reavers knew of Halfmoon, its secrets. Beyond them being a secretive society, of course. Which could explain *why* theyd sought them out. But this felt a bold assumption, nonetheless.

But the reality was that Catra *was* still hungry. The blood of humans and magicats was sustaining but it was a constant hunger, a dull throb that was ever present. And Adora's blood smelt of iron and salt and *so much* .

Almost unconsciously Catra opened her mouth and her tongue flicked out. She intended to lick and settle back, but Adora pressed the finger to the flat of the magicat's tongue. The taste assailed her and Catra blinked as Adora gently traced the finger across her coarse muscle, then pushed the finger into Catra's mouth. The magicat blinked and sucked for a moment, then Adora withdrew the finger.

The taste was strange - like a human's but *richer* . It was earth, heady, suffused with something else.

And Catra felt the throb in herself dim *further* . She almost sagged with a strange sense of relief. A purr rumbled through her and she gasped. Next to her , Glimmer sat, slack jawed. And Bow looked to have a strange mixture of shock and fascination on his features.

Adora stood and nodded with a smile, "We have eaten at the same table. Our hearth is yours this night and none shall raise blade or bow to you, our guests. Now, let's get the mead flowing!"

The blonde turned and spread her arms, leaving Catra stunned and a little off balance. The seafolk returned to their tasks and Catra blinked in surprise when she suddenly found a platter of roasted fish set in front of her.

Whilst she drank blood, she could still *eat* normally. It helped as it provided sustenance, but blood was required to keep her otherworldly abilities strong and her hunger at bay. And the fish smelled amazing. She blinked, and plucked a hunk of it free with her claws, then took a bite and groaned.

Her ears twitched as she heard the approach of her own contingent - Pan, Weaver and one or two other soldiers. Adora, moving about the fire, flicked her gaze over to them, even though they were *clearly* a good few dozen yards away *and* moving quietly .

The warrior had keen senses, it appeared.

"You have a ghoul."

The question was delivered with a drawl and a faint purse of Adora's lips. Catra's gaze took the blonde in and she noticed that that the woman's expression was now more neutral, almost stony . Catra frowned back, suddenly unsure at this turn.

"A ghoul?"

The other seafarers also turned and Catra could hear the strange growl that came from several of their throats.

Pan crossed into the firelight, the two men behind him escorting Shadow Weaver between them. He looked at Catra and frowned, as he took in her expression, "My lady?..."

"Captain, join us. And...um...have some of the men come share the food with our...hosts."

"Hosts, ma'am?" Pan's gaze flicked to Adora and the gathered sea-folk, who were all spread across the clearing.

"It's their campfire. Apparently," Catra rolled her eyes, still a little edgy. "Plus...this *fish*..." Catra skewered a piece on her claw and brought it to her mouth, "It's fresh."

"As you wish, my lady," he nodded to one of the men, who handed the chain to Pan, then headed back to the magicat tents. The Captain pulled the sorceress closer to the group and Adora stepped forwards and regarded the chains.

"A gift? You wish for us to kill it?"

Catra looked at her and laughed, "No...no, she's a...tool. Sort of a useful thing to keep around."

Adora's face twisted in confusion, "But why?"

"She can use magic. And, well...never waste a resource."

The blonde turned her face to the sorceress and shrugged, then moved back to her seat. She unsheathed her dagger again and speared the hunk of meat, "Still think you should let me kill her."

"Maybe she doesn't want to hurt the thing," drawled Duncan. He was a bulky fellow, with a bushy set of facial hair. His clothing was thick and made him look even broader. He settled on another log and

regarded the bedraggled Weaver, "Hmm. this one's a Necromancer, aye."

Adora snorted, "Hardly. Not like Kaldor. This one seems weak."

"Who's Kaldor?" asked Bow. The seafarers exchanged glances, then looked to Adora. She ate a little more, then placed her food in front of her, and leaned her elbows on her knees.

"No small question. But we have eaten. And we have yet to get *really* in our cups so," she grinned at the Brightmooners and magicats, "I suppose we better talk *arrangements*."

Chapter End Notes

Aye some more worldbuilding and slow burn.

Did ya LIKE THAT!

Dancing amidst the flames

Chapter Summary

Adora tells their history

An offer is made

The price suggested

Chapter Notes

This one I am still working on, fear not!

Hope you enjoy this little drabble.

Oh for the music... think:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iUacGkg8

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer shifted on her log and cocked her head to one side, "Arrangements?" she asked, "Have you not already committed to our aid?"

The firelight reflected in the warrior-woman's eyes, the blue becoming like glistening sapphires in its flickering aura. She glanced briefly at Weaver then looked to Duncan and grinned. It was a lopsided near-smirk, full of knowing humour. Her eyes drifted to Catra briefly and the magicat felt her heart stutter once more. Adora nodded slowly, then spoke, "Man at Arms, Shield brother... bring the tambor and the drum. I think we should set the *why* of it all."

“And the players?” asked the bearded man.

“Teela, myself, and Kyle.”

Teela scoffed, “Really?”

“He does a good Kildor! Plus he has the bony structure to himself.”

“Be kind, or Rog will growl at you.”

“Ach, we have until we get home before then. I will have time to hide!” Adora grinned again, “To be on the safe side. I’d be more worried about Lonnie, but she would say I was not harsh enough.”

“Some days I envy Kyle. Some I fear for his sanity,” sighed Teela. She moved off to a nearby group who sat around their own fire and leaned down to speak to them. A few more of the Seafarers had unfurled strange instruments from wrapped-leather satchels. Something that looked like a lyre, but with some sort of bow to it, as well as a stretched hide drum, and what looked like just a drum top, stretched over a wooden hoop. Catra peered at all this with interest, thoroughly confused.

Adora stood and dusted off her britches. Her smile became soft as a gangly looking seafarer jogged to the campfire, followed by Teela. Adora grappled the lad and held him in a headlock for a moment,

then scruffed his hair. The boy pulled away and growled, but it sounded more amused than actually threatening. Adora made a huffing noise and Catra's gaze moved to this newcomer. She'd thought he was a boy, but he was a man - just with thin wisps of a beard instead. He had a nervous disposition, but smiled at the group. Adora grasped his shoulder, then leaned in to whisper something. He's expression became serious and he nodded, then moved around the fire, adjusting the leather bandolier across his woolen-armour. Teela shot him a wink and Catra found herself leaning forwards expectantly.

Adroa hung her head forwards, long blonde hair draped down, the braided portion like a coil of rope. She flexed her wrists and then rolled her shoulders. Slowly the seafarers all quietened and Catra noticed that several others from their own fires had turned to watch.

The seafarers with instruments began to play - a low, thumping beat, with the haunting whine of the stringed lyre-thing. It built and built as Teela, He and Adora stamped their feet in time. Teela stepped around the fire, her body moving like a serpent, arms sinuous as she danced, feet stamping out a purposeful beat. Duncan leaned forwards and began to speak. It wasn't *quite* singing, but his words flowed with the beat of the song. He seemed to sing from his throat, a strange, deep note to his voice.

"Long our people lived / to hunt and sing.

The land our own / the beasts to burden

And hope to bring."

Adora jerked up and rolled her shoulders. Teela moved around her, hands trailing over the warrior-woman’s shoulders. But Adora’s eyes locked onto Catras, even as the blonde flexed and rolled her body .

“Beneath the stars / we found our way

Our clan songs loud / our prey sublime

Peace to stay.”

He rocked and twisted, then flung his head back, jaw vibrating in a silent cackle. His arms stretched out and he staggered around the fire to grasp at Teela. His movements were disjointed, but also in time with the music, his hunched dance in tune yet also clearly sinister.

“But not to be / for darkness came.

The dead did walk / the light did fall

Never was our land the same.”

He grabbed T eela and the pair spun, the woman’s red hair flung out like a wave. Adora gyrated and stomped while the fire flickered against her frame, casting her face in shadows. Catra couldnt help but stare, enraptured as the beat thudded away - it stirred in her gut, like the purr of family, the growl of the hunt and the rumble of something far more intimate.

The seafarers had their own chorus of unintelligible rumbles that acted as a sort of echo to the music, a throat-song of some sort. He hunched over and made a silent cackle. In her head Catra imagined it would probably be an *Eh Eh EH* sort of laugh.

“Kydor stalked / shadows walked

The land did die / hearth grew cold

The clan path forked,”

Catra snorted at that but bit her lip as Duncan arched an eyebrow at her. Then Adora rolled her shoulders and braced her arms. Duncan chuckled as he spoke.

“But strife breeds valour / darkness light

Adam, He / Man of war,

Led us in our desperate fight,”

Adora’s flexing was a bit exaggerated, her expression overly cocky. But the song took a dour note and her expression clouded as she flung Teela towards Adora. The way the red head clung to the tall blonde made Catra frown, but she wasn’t sure quite *why*. To her side, Pan shot her a glance and Catra huffed and looked away briefly. Her second just bit back a knowing grin.

“Kydor marched / his army grew

Our people fought / our bastions fell

For Keldor raised all he slew ,”

Teela slid to the ground then jerked up, mimicking Kyle's moves. Kyle-as-Keldor cackled, his jaw going mechanically , exaggerating the skull-like quality as he drew his expression into a sneer . The trio moved around the fire in sync, in a mockery of jerking combat, Adora fighting Keldor , then Teela. Somehow, though Adora’s moves were more fluid, it worked, the beat of the drums, the haunting whine of the strings and the rumble of the seafarers chanting seemed to paint a picture.

‘Adam rode forth / T o slay the snake

A plan in mind / we held the line

He Keldor ’s head to take.”

Adora grappled with Teela, while other seafarers joined the dance, their moves blending with the others, some synchronised dance. The whole thing seemed improvised and yet they moved carefully, past one another, dancing in what looked like combat, yet in time to the beat. Leaps and ducks and spins and grapples. Nothing flamboyant or acrobatic, which was more the style of Magicat theatre;no, this had weight and each movement had weight to it.

Catra gasped as Kyle flowed between the bodies. He moved like a snake. His gangly form seemed actually threatening in this maelstrom of movement. The shadows and the bodies writhing

made the light of the fire dance and made her view shift as her eyes adjusted then fell into shadow.

And then Hordak was there, behind Adora, hands raised as claws.

"The battle long / shadows grew

Our peoples hope / felt lost

Hordak struck anew ,"

The hands descended, but Adora whipped about and caught them.

"The ground it shook / the bodies fell

Adora held the line / Greyskull true

We heard Hordak's death knell."

Hordak's head rocked back, face a mask of sudden terror. And then all the seafarers dropped as one, leaving Adora holding Hordak up with *one arm.* Catra felt suddenly very very warm.

"His head severed / the army died

Hordak's magic gone / no more to stalk the world

The evil it had tried.”

Adora dropped Kyle to the ground and he sprawled dramatically with an audible death rattle. That drew a few huffs from the other seafarers. Duncan tutted, but continued.

“The land it heals / Adam crowned

The cost was high / our clans were split

But the legend is renowned.”

Adora moved among the fallen, stalking like some sort of animal. She hauled Teela to her feet, then another seafarer, then another.

“And Kaldor’s head / taken as a prize

As prisoner to our whim / his maddened cries

Victory in our eyes.”

Kyle was hauled up by a pair of dancers and paraded about as he *chattered* maniacally. It really was unnerving.

“Our tale is one of pain / sacrifice and blood

Our victory bought with death / the fallen never forgot

And you are where we stood.

"The dark it comes / a second time

With flesh of stinking rot / of dead eyes and magic foul

In nature's eyes, a crime."

"So heed our voice / hear the clanfolk howl

See us rend them clean / their bones shattered hence

If victory be your goal."

The music tailed off as each seafarer moved away, out of the firelight, Ike hauled away as well, leaving only Adora to dance as the music tailed off naturally. AS the drums thudded a final beat, she flung back her head and *howled* . The other seafarers joined in, a raucous noise that had Catra's ears pinned back by the sudden, echoing ferocity of it.

And then it cut out. Adora, panting, looked about and then moved to clap Duncan on the shoulder , "Well sung, old man. It loses something in the Etherian, though?"

"Eh, it does its job."

The blonde grinned over at Catra, Glimmer and Bow, but her gaze settled on the Magicat, "A brief history ."

"What, you didn't have a scroll to hand?" Catra riposted. She felt the need to re-establish more of an equilibrium. She felt off balance; perhaps even a little flustered. Adora's grin was now a smirk.

"We enjoy tales. Adds flavour. Oh we have skalds record scrolls and epics and political flim flam. But there is something more honest with the body, the expression, the spoken word. It conveys more."

Glimmer nodded, "I mean, a lot of societies in Etheria have oratory and theatre as a way of explaining history . Don't even you guys do that?" she shot Catra a smirk of her own.

Adora looked between them, then nodded slowly as she stared at Catra, "Well, we are very proud of *our* oral traditions. I would love to learn some of yours as well, Catra."

The magicat had been reaching for her wine but froze as she narrowed her eyes at the blonde. There was an audible slap as Glimmer facepalmed. Bow, however, coughed *loudly* and then wheezed with a choked out "Went down the wrong way ."

"Yes, that can be a problem I hear," deadpanned Teela. The seafarers chuckled around her. Adora looked around.

"What? I did not say anything!" her grin, however, gave the lie to that sentiment. Catra inhaled and tried to steer the conversation.

"So you have fought the Horde and won?"

The blonde rested her elbows on her knees once more and nodded, "They advanced fast; killed the land, raised our dead - clanfolk and beasts alike. The warriors... those they found *harder* to raise, for good reason. But still, they swarmed us. We did force a deadlock when their lines spread too thin. They faltered at the edge of the desert, the heat too much for their frail bodies. They had numbers, but we had resilience. But it was a losing battle. Every one we lost added to their ranks. So, we realised we needed to strike to crush them. We formed a plan - hold their armies in place while a force took the fight to their most vulnerable point: their *leader."*

Glimmer blinked, "Their *leader* was what you identified as *vulnerable*?" her voice was shrill. Teela nodded.

"Yes. Hordor was powerful *but* ... an army of undead can be disrupted if you remove the things driving them. So, we struck their leaders. One by one, which destroyed entire legions at a time."

"Well... we could do *that*," scoffed Glimmer, "But if it was *that* simple"…

The blonde chuckled, "Well we... we bring something to the table."

Around the campfire the sailors nodded grimly. Catra quirked an eyebrow, "Oh?"

"Skill," Adora smiled back blandly, "We could carve our way through them and match their sorcerers in close combat. They are a terror with an army, but up close... they break. But I will admit it was not without challenges. For a warrior to fall, well... our skills can persist in death. A recent resurrection carries with it the skills it had in life. But a corpse not maintained with *their* foul magic will begin to regress, fail and become little more than a droning shambling *thing*. To keep a *ghoul* alive like her?" Adora spat towards Shadow Weaver, "Well, that takes... investment."

Glimmer made a distressed noise, "They were... preserving your people?"

Adora nodded, her eyes dark for a moment, "It is something to have to slay a friend who fought alongside you the day before. To have to hew them like a log so they can no longer fight. Our war was not war... it was butchery."

A chuckle came from Shadow Weaver, "And if only you dogs had submitted... We could have found a place for you. No need for..."

Adora's low growl sent shivers up Catra's spine once more. She had to suppress the sudden groan she felt in her throat and stifled her

surprise.. Shadow Weaver actually *whimpered* . The blonde stood and took a step forward.

"We won. Your master's *master* is now a trophy in our halls. He screeches for release. But we keep his head in a glass jar. A fitting punishment for one who trapped the bodies of the innocent. We have space...maybe Catra will gift you to me. We can see how many parts we can pull off you. See how well stitched together you are."

That made Catra pause. Pan looked at her with some mild alarm and she raised a hand, "She is not yours to dispose of."

Adora's blue eyes flicked towards the magicat. They were ice cold right up until they settled on Catra. Then the tension around them softened and Adora's grim set to her face melted into a smile, "Which is why I said you might gift her to me. This is my hearth...but your land. But while you may see her use, she is a danger, still. The Horde is drawn to its more powerful servitors."

"She is warded," huffed Catra, now mildly annoyed by the woman. Well, maybe not *annoyed* but still frustrated. She narrowed her eyes and Adora inclined her head in a conciliatory gesture. Glimmer took that moment to raise another point.

"Wait...did you say you kept Hordak's *head*? And it...speaks?"

"Of course. He is a lich. We have his phylactery as well Broken apart so he can only cling to life *barely."*

" Foolish girl, you let him live? He will rise again," snorted Shadow Weaver, "Clearly you dogs are as foolish as"…

"I said I would ask Catra. Do not make me break my promises. It makes me very sad to let people down," drawled Adora. Duncan chuckled.

"She gets very particular , ghoul."

The blonde nodded, "And we know . Adam is wise enough to decide. When I left, Hordor still…Lived. It is likely that has been rectified. Likely sealed into a molten core of metal and then sunk to the bottom of a deep pit," Adora sighed and nodded, "Better than letting whatever carries for a spirit to go wandering, wouldnt you agree?"

Shadow Weaver cringed back, her chains rattling. Adora's grin was faintly feral, the firelight now glinting from her white teeth. Then she looked to Teela. The red head nodded and planted her hands on her hips.

"So, we are here to discuss terms. We have beaten the Horde in our lands and know how to fight them. How to *defeat* them. What is it you need of us?"

Catra leaned forwards herself, "What makes you think we *need* anything?"

Adora sighed and stared into Catra's Amber and blue eyes, "Shall we not dance about this? Do you not wish the Horde defeated? Or do you wish them to *win*?"

Pan hissed at that and Adora looked at him blankly. Then she snorted and raised her hands. She made a "Raw" noise, like a kitten would. The seafarers chuckled around her. Catra stifled her own snort and schooled her features into a glare - it wouldn't do to mock her own soldier, even if he had made such a blindly obviously childish response.

"We don't want them to win. We just don't see them as much of an *immediate* threat or one we cannot handle at least."

"This is not what your friend says. It appears the Horde here ravages land and folk alike. We made the mistake of ignoring them at first. Their invasion was swift, but our response was, by fortune's grace, swifter. Bloody and hard fought though it was, we struck where and when we needed to and we stopped the bloodshed from escalating," she levelled a finger at Catra, "You would be wise to do the same. Just offering that out there."

The truth was, the Horde were pressing hard against their surface settlements, those that were tithed to Halfmoon. But to show

desperation in a negotiation was poor. These weren't allies *yet* , even if their leader was ridiculous attractive, well proportioned and with a scent that… *focus Catra* , the magicat scolded herself.

She looked up into the night sky and marshalled her thoughts, "We have noticed an uptick in aggression, tactics and the like. I will grant you that. But if it was simply a case of more bodies to fight.well, we can have that *here* . What do you offer?"

Adora's grin was predatory again, "Well, that is the question is it not? We can offer you a way to *win* ."

"And what will it cost *us* ?"

The blond tilted her head to one side, "A trifling thing."

Catra smirked, "Of course. And what would that be?"

Adora's eyes bored into Catra's and her smile became a languid half grin, "Your most gifted warrior and highest of your court. As my mate."

Chapter End Notes

So, yeah, Adora does tribal Nordic dance while a skald tells the epic. Not my best, but I wanted to convey a feel - poetry / prose is definitely NOT a strong suit of mine.

Let me know if you liked. Well start to see these two idiots get a little closer soon. This is a short AU after all... (he says.... as we know I totally stick to chapter counts...)

Let me know if you liked. I did write this while in a sleepless fugue so if there's anything that seems of f LET ME KNOW!

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

Adora explains herself. But not really .

Catra is supicious.

The hunt is on.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra had been raised in Halfmoon's court;taught to school herself, to guard her emotions where necessary;to protect against rivals. Yes, Shadow Weaver had been a threat all her own, but that was still one the royal family had managed to adapt to. But everyday court intrigue and how to behave and control conversation?That was Catra's bread and butter.

So she maintained eye contact with the blonde warrior woman and quirked an eyebrow , "A *trifle* , is it?You feel we are just a small regional *principality* that can be condescended to?"

For a brief moment the blonde looked a little perplexed, possibly even flustered as she eyed Catra. Admittedly, the magicat was doing her best haughty look. It wasnt much of an act - a *trifle* was she? Yes this woman was damnably attractive, but she wasnt going to be tempted. An attraction was one thing, but to be tied to some sea-raiding barbarian?It would be too much. She had no desire to be wed. She was a warrior, in the prime of her life. To be tied down, to become some kept being in a hall?No.

But then this woman did not know *she* was the intended.

Adora looked at the ground and shrugged, "Is that not how it is done here? To cement things with marriage? To bind families and clans together with the strongest of bonds?"

"You equate family with strength, do you?" chuckled Catra, "Family can just be those who can hurt you the most."

Adora's eyes came up again and fixed on Catra, "That seems a forlorn way to view things. You do not value closeness, familiarity in your kingdom then? There is no place for love and kindness?"

The tone was sad, but coupled with that piercing gaze, Catra felt she was being tested again. The other warriors listened and suddenly Catra felt she was centre of attention. She huffed.

"That is a simplistic view . Family life and the life of nobility... they are estranged. A political marriage might not be one of joy. It is, as you say, a *deal* . To be forced into such a thing is... well it is something that takes negotiation and"…

"Is this not what we are doing?" Adora shrugged.

Catra huffed, "And what if our highest is not pleased with this arrangement?"

Adora's smirk was cocky as anything, "I feel she might be amenable."

"You are so sure it is a woman, are you?"

The blonde looked up to the sky. She gestured at the stars, "Do you look at the sky often, Catra?"

The magicat was puzzled by this derailment, "...what does that have to do with anything?"

"Do you feel that they tell the future? Guide our destinies? What are the stars to you?"

The warrior woman seemed contemplative. Catra glanced at Glimmer who looked as puzzled as the magicat. But her expression morphed into a smirk as she gave a faint head jerk towards Adora, then waggled her eyebrows. Catra glared back at the sparkling fairy and the huffed. In a sing song voice she responded, "No, we don't believe they tell the future. They are useful for predicting seasons and the like."

"Do you not stare at them in wonder? Consider what they are? We use them to navigate the seas and the plains. The world around us changes but the stars... they seem eternal. Distant but present, no?"

"All very mystical, I'm sure. We're getting off topic."

Adora shrugged slowly, "Are we? This is important. You understand the stars one way, we another. You see mating one way, we another. You see it as a... duty? A trial to be endured perhaps?"

Catra bristled and leaned forwards, "It is a necessity. But for a *Princess* to marry one such as... you... would have to be worthwhile. No mercenary is worth such a bonding."

She expected Adora to react, to sneer and snarl and posture. But the warrior pursed her lips and nodded, contemplating, "This is, of course, a valid point. And you have yet to see what we can offer you. I suppose asking for payment without an example of capability is perhaps... overmuch?"

"Adora," chided Duncan, "They can barter on their own behalf."

Catra chuckled at that, "You really are not good at this, Adora."

The blonde leaned her head back and laughed. Catra couldn't help but watch her throat. The pulse there wasn't the *only* thing she was drawn to. Then Adora's head came back down and those storm-blue eyes locked back into Catra, "Am I indeed? Perhaps I am merely showing the best of us," She leaned forward once more and rested her forearms on her knees, "To us, a binding is a bringing together of clans. A unity, a solemn promise. To honour and respect the other, to be stalwart. Oaths are our blood. To break an oath is to be no longer one of us."

Around the fire the other warriors rumbled. A couple spat into the flames. One glared up into the sky, "Kydor."

"Yes," Adora nodded again, "Kydor was an oathbreaker. We sundered our lands to repay the debt of blood owed. And we stood by those who swore to us. But a deal is not forever-binding. We know that the heart is a fickle thing - that people might become different. A parting of the ways is sometimes a necessary thing. So, to soothe your rancor, any coupling could be annulled should it be *disatisfying*," and again he smirk returned, "But I do not intend to be disatisfying."

Teela groaned as the seafarers made mocking noises. Adora rolled her eyes and made a gesture that Catra assumed to be fairly rude in the Seafarer culture. She straightened, "All very *nice*. So, you would spirit your bride away and keep her as a hostage in your lands, then what? You bring your people here, begin to settle, slowly encroach? And we have yet to see your offering, as you say."

The blonde's brow furrow and she cocked her head to one side, "You think the worst of us already? A pity. But perhaps you have reason to?" Adora glanced to Glimmer, then back to Catra. A thought seemed to occur and she bit her lip, "Does.is there another?"

That caught Catra off guard. Adora seemed, what, disappointed at the idea? For the first time since meeting the tall woman, Catra saw uncertainty in those eyes. It was oddly unnerving and she had an urge to correct it, "What, no. But, you haven't answered the question."

The small expression of relief on Adora's face warmed Catra for some reason. Except Adora didn't know it was *Catra* who was the potential betrothed candidate. So was Adora just desperate for a mate? And what a strange term - Magicats used it, but it was an older name, from back during the pack-clan days.

"This is good. And.why would I want a hostage? I seek a shieldmaiden, a battle sister to watch my back in the sword-song and the claw dance. A companion to brave the wilds and waters. Why marry then leave them in a hall? What coupling is that?" Adora seemed genuinely puzzled, "I would not wish to be *Teela* who seems eager to leave her beloved behind."

Teela made a sound of affronted shock, then lunged across the camp to swat at Adora. The blonde leaned away from the swipe and barked a laugh as she pushed the other warrior backwards. The pair tumbled across the camp and Catra blinked at the sudden rough and tumble. Next to her, Pan looked startled, whilst Shadow Weaver recoiled in disgust. Teela and Adora scrambled and Catra found herself getting oddly irritated.

Then Adora did a complicated move and had Teela pinned to the ground, her arm held in a lock, "Submit! And admit my brother bores you!"

"Never!"

"Gah! Then why not stay to warm his bedroll?" teased Adora, "Or is it secretly me you pine for!"

The Seafarers made mocking jeers at that, while Teela began to laugh. Adora huffed and released the woman, then stood and helped her up. The red head rolled her eyes and shoved Adora's shoulder once more, while Adora shrugged and shot her a grin. Teela glanced at Catra then back at Adora, "We all know your dreams, Adora. Raz crows them enough. I would not stand the competition. And Adam warms me well enough… But the chance to wet my blade once more"…

Adora nodded at that and glanced briefly over at Catra again. And then, strangely, blushed. It was the first time she had and it covered her neck and face. She made her way back to her seat and slumped down, then looked back to the magicat, "Apologies. We are a familiar people."

"No need. We encourage our kits to do the same."

Adora arched an eyebrow, "So you believe us children, eh? A culture that has no joy in marriage and despises fun... Interesting," but the blonde's lips quirked into a teasing smirk. Glimmer chuckled.

"It's all that time underground. Time to brood. The whole woe-is-me culture," she stuck her tongue out at Catra.

"Better than drinking tea from flowers and barfing up pixie dust all the time," growled Catra. She turned back to Adora, "So, you offer a political alliance. We may need more understanding of the tangible benefits. It's a lot to ask for just... military assistance."

"Precisely, my lady. These curs would beg you into a demeaning alliance. Why give a Princess to them. They will take and take. I know them. They are raiders. Conquerors. The Horde is at least *direct*. They would bleed you, inch by inch."

Adora's eyes flicked to Shadow Weaver. Her knife came up, ready to be thrown and Shadow Weaver's eyes went wide. But Adora paused and looked to Catra, then sheathed her blade.

"Military assistance that will end this war quicker and spare you a drawn out campaign against a force that will poison your lands and people," Adora's answer was quick and formal. The change in tone was sudden and Catra felt wrong footed again. The blonde just shrugged and looked back at the stars, "The stars guide us. They do not dictate our destiny. I know what I want, what *I need*," she stood

abruptly, "The question is do *you* know what you want, Catra? Does the Princess know?"

The warrior turned to Glimmer and spoke some words in their language, the first time they'd been closed to the others. The man nodded in return, then darted off into the woods, his speed surprising. Catra swallowed and frowned at Glimmer, who just shrugged in puzzlement. The fairy then coughed and leaned to get Adora's attention, "Can the Brightmoon Kingdoms offer anything more? I know we have your support but…"

Adora gave a lazy smile, "No, Glimmer. All is well. Catra, we will show what we can do. Then you may decide. For now, thank you for welcoming us. We can speak more about precise details next evening. I imagine you would be more comfortable with that?"

Catra met Adora's gaze and nodded slowly. These Seafarers were well informed. Very few, *very few* beyond the mountain knew of Catra, her standing. Oh in the city she was known. But beyond, not easily by sight. And Glimmer had not betrayed her confidence, that she knew. This was perplexing. But was this a slip of the tongue? Did they, did Adora *know*? As far as they knew Catra was just an envoy. Had Adora just assumed, based on the fact that the Fairies had sent *their* Princess to negotiate?

Certainly something to ponder.

She stood and gave a short bow to Adora who just nodded in return. Strangely, Catra felt disappointed about that. Like a barrier of sorts had come down and that Adora was now reserved. The boisterous warrior was now formal, guarded.

She led Pan and Shadow Weaver back towards their tents. Dawn's light was peeking over the horizon, making the ocean, barely visible through the trees, glisten like sapphire. The sun would not kill them, but it made them lethargic and weak. The mortal soldiers would have to be on guard, the ones afflicted by the curse would be "bloodied up" to remain awake.

But oddly, Catra didn't feel the pull of day's normal torpor. Underground the feeling was lessened, to a degree where most of her kind could operate pretty much all day and night. But in the direct sun? It normally made her tired, grumpy and cantankerous to a ridiculous degree. Now, however, she felt only mildly drowsy, as if she'd just had a busy day.

"Mistress?"

"Hm? Oh. See to the ghoul. I will retire. I must compose a letter to mother."

"Be sure to send her my regards," sneered Shadow Weaver. Catra shook her head and smirked as Pan tugged the woman along, with no small amount of malice.

Inside her tent Catra penned a quick note, then handed it to one of the courier soldiers. They'd ceased to use messenger birds after the Horde made use of those awful imp things. Catra couldn't help but shudder at the memory of them.

Grumbling, Catra stripped off her armour and set it aside carefully. She hunkered down onto her bedroll and drew the thick blankets over herself. Normally the sheer fact that it was day would knock her out as soon as she rested her head. Yet now... now she found herself tossing and turning. The tent was dark, made of thick material with drapes all over to minimise the light. And yet she felt it, felt the burning curse beyond the fabric.

Glimmer and her entourage would have no doubt retreated to their magical little tents that would have just been popped into existence. Likely to spend the day amidst the trees and *frolicking* or something. Maybe even spending more time with the Seafarers.

That irked her. These strange visitors were here to see the magicats, had requested an audience, but had then dismissed them? Yes it had been *morning* and it could be argued that was Adora showing some consideration - they clearly understood and knew all about the various rumours of Halfmoon. But why had Adora gone from sharing her blood to suddenly being a wall?

Catra growled to herself and flung her blanket off herself. Her tail lashed from side to side as she sat up and she ran her tongue across her fangs. She glared at the tent flaps and heaved a sigh, "Why can't I *sleep*?" She closed her eyes, but the only thing that bubbled up was the image of blue eyes.

Mdreams. Surely it can't mean what Ithink it does? It' s just a silly superstition.

But her blood - the taste was *intoxicating* . Catra groaned and fell back onto the bedroll, "It' s just blood drunkeness. That's all. She just.tastes new . That's all. Just a coincidence. Some muscular woman turns up and you go to pieces - you are the gods damned *princess* of Halfmoon. And you will not trade anything away, not for a pretty face or good shoulders or... NO! And definitely not because she thinks she can do some fun fighting. No. You are worth *more* than that."

SHe tossed and turned for a while, then yanked her pillow over her head and screamed into it as sleep continued to evade her. The ongoing fight against wakefulness was rudely interrupted, however, by a commotion outside her tent. There seemed to be an argument, then shrieking. Catra groaned and hauled herself out through the tent entrance.

Outside, her camp had been invaded. Well, not *quite* . Several Seafarers were standing *inside* the camp, surrounded by nervous guards. Catra groaned, then frowned as she noted Teela at the forefront. She had a weird spike of irritation as she looked at the red-head. Then she noticed that The Seafarers were pointing towards the raggedy tent where Shadow Weaver was kept.

"What the hells is going on out here?"

Teela glanced over and grinned at Catra. She gave the magicat a quick once over and nodded with apparent approval, "I can see why she likes you."

"When you're done treating me like some brood mare, mind explaining why you're in *my* camp, causing a ruckus. Maybe give me a reason not to have my guards fillet one of you to set an example?"

Teela gave another approving nod, "Sensible approach. I mean you could try, but why bother? Y our pet ghoul has caused a problem. But it presented us with an opportunity."

"And what is that then?" growled Catra, She reached up to run a hand through her mane and realised that it was a tad unkempt - clearly she'd been flailing a lot more than she realised. Growling, she fussed it into a semblance of normalcy. More movement drew her eye and she noticed a worried looking Glimmer hopping from one foot to the other just beyond the camp boundary, "Stop that, Sparkles. You look like you need the privy. So. Tola, what's up?"

Teela snorted, more a chuffing noise, and grinned at Catra, "Really? Anyway, there is a Horde skirmishing party half a league away. Some.two hundred bodies."

Catra blinked then shot a look at Pan, "What."

"My lady..the scouts haven't reported"…

"They wont have because they are likely ensorceled," hummed Teela, "That or the Horde snuck through. Or killed them. Or your scouts simply havent managed to return- ah"…

A rider thundered into camp, looking harried, "My lady..there' s"…

"A Horde skirmishing party half a league away?" drawled Catra. She didnt stop staring at Teela as she spoke, her eyes narrowed. The scout stammered and adjusted himself in the saddle, the leather of his armour creaking as he did so.

"Y ...yes my l-"

" *Wonderful* . Get the horse watered and grab some food. Then we break camp and go see for ourselves..and how did *you* know about this before *us* , hmmm? Seems awful..convenient."

Sparkles had sidled up, but seemed to have the same thought process Catra did. She narrowed her eyes at Teela, "I have to agree with Catra. Seems very convenient timing."

Teela shrugged, "Adora told you. They are drawn to their leaders. How many times has she been above ground, hmmm?

Catra blinked in surprise, then narrowed her eyes as she watched Tela jerk her chin towards Weaver's tent, "What's that got…"

"They are drawn to them. Distance does not matter. They feel the pull. It is soul-deep. They sense the rot in their very essence. You can see it there," she pointed to the tent. Around it the grass was slowly dying. Catra blinked in surprise.

"She's…she's warded though. And…nothing like that happens in… in Halfmoon."

"Yes. I imagine not," drawled Teela, "Much life down there? Does she mingle? She cannot draw from anything so easily. But simple things? Plants? It is as to them as breathing is to most beings. I do not understand it. I am no wise woman or midwife. All we know is that they are like lanterns to moths. You sealed her flame in glass, but the light of the lamp spills out."

Glimmer looked to Catra, then back at Teela, "You…expected this?"

"Of course. Adora knew they would come. Also…well, I shall let her explain. Should she wish to."

"Well, I guess. We need to deal with this," groused Catra. Another village lost would be a blow - more refugees, more mouths to feed and less land to tend, "Get Adora, well…I guess see what she can do."

Teela chuckled, "She is gone."

Catra blinked, "She... left?"

"Of course. We could not stop her."

"She.. fled?" Catra bristled and then startled back as all the Seafarers, Teela included, *snarled* . The red head stepped forwards, only to be barred by Pan stepping in front of Catra. Teela looked at him, then down at where his hand rested on his sword. Her eyes flicked back up to him and her features shifted into a lazy smile.

"Paw and die. Makes no bones to me. It would upset Adora though. And you... I have not cut you as you are Adora's *sjelevenn* . But do not besmirch her honour. She who trod the cracks of the world and held the walls of Greyskull. No, she has gone to meet the enemy."

Catra blinked, then noticed that the Seafarer camp was still bustling, "...but... you have people *here* ."

Teela looked over her shoulder, then back at Catra. She shrugged, "She has her hunting band. I doubt they will keep pace. She is ever eager for the fray. But I have come to bring you."

Catra was feeling very dazed - she was awake in the sun, she hadn't rested and now was being challenged in her own camp by some pirate barbarian. Because, apparently, the *other* pirate barbarian had gone off to take on a Horde band *by herself* . These people were insane.

A sound cut through the air. It made Catra's hackles rise, but not in fear - in… *anticipation* ? It was a howl, a war cry . It carried through the trees and echoed around, faint and distant. Teela's grin was feral as she leaned her head back and yelled out an answering howl. The other Seafarers took up the cry and punched the air. Teela dropped her head, her eyes sparkling, "The hunt has begun. T ry to keep up."

The Seafarers turned as one and ran out into the trees. Catra watched as most of the camp nearby emptied out. She frowned, then looked at Glimmer, who looked back at her, equally confused. It was Bow who asked the question.

"They don't have any horses"?

Catra chuckled, "This should be easy then. Alright, saddle up. Sparkles, help me sort my armour out. Let's see what all this fuss is about with your pet barbarians."

"My pets"? I wasn't the one making eyes at a slab of blonde meat last night."

“Shut. Up. And help me sort my armour out.”

Glimmer actually cackled as she followed Catra into the tent.

“Sure thing blood-scum. I have a good feeling about this.”

Catra worried at her lip, her tongue tasting the phantom rush of Adora’s strange blood. Her mind pondered over the meaning of her dreams. Over choices and destiny and duty. She sighed and glanced at the fairy, “W ell see.”

Chapter End Notes

Will I fit this into 5 chapters?! WHO KNOWS (Y ou know. You all know....)

Conclusion

Chapter Summary

> Battle is met, blood is spilled and admissions are made as these two envoys of their people witness the glory of war together.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The ride through the woods was slow going - though paths and woodsman-ways wended through the trees, the horses could only move at a canter. The light of day meant that going was harder on the more tired of her brethren. She was stronger than most, her bloodline making her more resilient. But Pan and the others were wrapped tight against the suns rays. It wouldnt burn them, or shrivel them to dust like some of the old wive's tales said.

It did give them a hell of a head-buzthough. Sun-drunk the sages called it. Magicats were historically drawn to light, which was why the curse was so unpleasant - sunlight practically knocked any cursed being out, rendering them comatose now. Their bodies would weaken, their reactions would be dulled. Any sleep taken in the light of day would not be restorative and leave the person weak, hungry and confused.

Freshly fed, they could resist it, but they wouldnt be at their peak. So, her mortal guards would be her main defence.

They thundered onwards, the Seafarers lost among the thick branches and tangled icy of the forest floor. Catra caught glimpses of them, moving between trees with a terrifying speed and uniformity. They reminded her of hunting dogs;she'd attended a human hunt, where a lord had shown off his "freshly trained pack";it had been a studied insult, of course - showing a pack of dogs to a magicat.

Of course, the poor beasts had cowered away from her, then fled, abandoning the hunt, much to the lord's chagrin and Catra's glee. But she'd seen them attempt to work together . The Seafarers moved like that, never in each other's way, vanishing between the shadowy trees.

They moved deeper into the woods, the dark of the canopy offering blessed relief. Catra wove through another tangle of branches then hauled on her reins. She stared at the scene before her.

A corpse was impaled to a tree. It wasnt one of the Seafarers - the body was armour glad, the sickly green of the Horde - the flesh papery and withered. She wasnt surprised to see a Horde scout. No, what was surprising was that the spear impaling the soldier had punched through the armour, then the tree and had come out *the other side* .

A foot of solid tree trunk.

She heard her soldiers muttering among themselves and she clucked her tongue to silence them, "They have some tricks. Mayhap

that man-at-arms has a good throwing arm.”

That drew a chuckle or two, but it was muted. With a kick, Catra spurred her horse on. Twigs snapped as her troop moved out of the thicker mess of trees into a more sparse copse. Through the thinning branches she scanned the sky for smoke, perked her ears up to listen for screams. A frown creased her forehead - she couldnt hear anything, aside from the chirp of birds.

‘My lady?’

She glanced at Pan, next to her. Behind him, on a smaller horse, Shadow Weaver was hunched, extra warded shackles draped over her frail form. The hag sneered at Catra, her elfin features twisted in a scowl. Catra snorted and looked back at her Captain.

‘No smoke. No fires. No screaming refugees. Thoughts?’

‘We’re too late?’ He blinked, blearily. He was tough, but daylight took a toll. Catra tsked.

‘No, I think Adora and her band may have delayed their forces. Gives us a chance to defend the village. It’s...Thaymor isnt it?’

“Aye, my lady. We shouldn’t be far off. I can see a field yonder, where the tree line breaks.”

Catra nodded, then wheeled her horse and kicked it to a trot. She huffed as they advanced, her eyes scanning through the trees, “Need to get the council to get more roads paved. Will make moving the troops to any front better,” she muttered to herself.

The troop broke through the forest line and onto the field. The harvest had recently been taken in, leaving short stalks of wheat on hard soil. A few hundred yards beyond sat a small cluster of houses - the village of Thaymor.

Nothing was burning. No villagers were fleeing or screaming or being dragged off to supplement the ravening mass of bodies that was the Horde.

Indeed, the only oddity was a lone figure near the edge of the village. Catra spared Pan a glance, then jingled her reins and urged her horse forwards. They trotted across the field and Catra blinked in surprise as she took in the figure.

He leaned against a low stone wall, shirtless. His armour was stacked nearby and he wore only a set of ragged britches.

What was more interesting was the bodies littered beyond the wall, around the village. Clad in Horde armour, they appeared to be in

various states of dismemberment. Catra stared, while her troops advanced into the village. She blinked slowly as she took in the carnage, then looked down at Kyle.

The Seafarer had a smile on his face. Blood caked his forearms and his expression was relaxed, "Good morrow, Lady Catra. A fine day, yknow?"

"Indeed," she responded, flatly, "Where are the villagers?"

"Some were taken, Im afraid. We sent the rest north, by road. Well, told them to go that way while we dealt with the scouting party here. Adora is over yonder, one of the hamlets being raided that away."

"You did this?"

"Hmm? Oh, mostly Adora. I got those five there. One of them stuck me though, had to sit down and have a breather, yknow?"

"Stuck you?" managed Catra. Kyle nodded and pointed at his side. An angry red line was visible there, but it looked more like a graze than a wound.

"Yeah, one of those, yknow, um, cleaver things. Got it in good. But he got his! Not sure where his head went though," the blonde man

mumbled absently as he looked about. He shrugged and rolled his skinny shoulders, "Managed to stop them before they set the place aflame, too!"

The way he said it, it was like he was expecting praise, or approval. But his expression was one of almost cheeky enjoyment. Like he was proving a point. And considering Adora had said she wished to be betrothed to the best warrior of the Magicats.was this them trying to demonstrate *something* ?

"Good.job, I guess?" managed Catra, still shocked at the absolute brutality of how the Horde troops had been taken apart. And she realised that was an apt description - they had been practically dismantled. Limbs and torsos. Not really a full body between them.

She startled at a strangled cry behind her, then turned in the saddle. Shadow Weaver looked distraught as she looked at the carnage. The look of frustration, irritation and near-anguish on the woman's face was oddly reassuring - the scene was one the witch had not expected. Then the hag glared at Kyle.

"Abomination!Y ou have *sullied* them."

Kyle winced and scratched his head, "Nah. Just, yknow...made it harder to redeploy them," he fixed the witch with an easy gaze and shrugged, "So, um, whoops?"

"I will skin you and"…

"Shut up, hag," drawled Catra. Now, as she looked again, she realised that he had a point - any Necromancer would have to pour a *lot* of power into getting these troops back up. That was the issue with the Horde - you cut them down, but they could always get back up. Fire or dismemberment were the only effective ways to disrupt them - which was no easy task. In a melee, against a normal foe, a stab wound to the gut, a slash to the leg and you had your foe down and out. The undead? The effort it took to subdue *one* opponent meant it was a battle of attrition - fights in open fields became mud-and-blood strewn battlefields, the dead *always* coming out better as they just pressed on. Each living soldier had to spent ages hacking, cutting, burning to down even a single opponent. The dead just had to kill one man and that man joined their ranks as the Horde commanders resurrected them.

But Adora's troops seemed to have it well in hand. Not a single casualty from the Seafarers. And he had been stabbed but seemed none the worse for wear. His healing seemed almost as good as those of the cursed in Halfmoon. Unless it had just been a graze and he was playing it up to relax here. Maybe he had been about to do some looting? After all, they were raiders.

Though why was he half naked?

"Pan, leave some men here, check the buildings for survivors. Send a detachment along the road to bring the refugees to safety. The rest of you, with me."

"You might want to leave her here," mused Kyle as he rummaged around his armour. He straightened and gestured at Shadow Weaver, "just in case."

Catra frowned at him then shook her head, "I'd rather she be where I can see her. And where you might not be tempted to off her."

The young man shrugged, "Suit yourself."

"Oh thank you, Kyle, I will," Catra rolled her eyes and spurred her horse once more. Behind her Pan issued several orders and a cohort of the men peeled off to carry out her orders. She set her horse to a canter out of the village, towards the distant sounds of battle, faintly audible on the breeze.

The horses thundered down the road and Catra noted more signs of battle - arrow riddled corpses, bodies cut down by blades;some, sadly, her own people - villagers who had been in the fields early, caught off guard. SHe gritted her teeth, angry at herself, at her fellow leaders. It was irritating to realise that this Seafarer and, worse, *Glimmer* was right. They needed to do more.

Her troop rounded a bend in the road and cantered up a low rise. They crested the ridge and found an odd sight.

Seafarers - spread out across the ridge, dragging bodies and joking with one another. Below lay a valley with a small hamlet at its base. Catra could see several figures below, fighting against the remnants of the Horde troops. It was still a sizeable force, however. She could hear the clash of steel and strange, animalistic bellows - some Horde abominations in the fray perhaps?

She noticed that several of the Seafarers seemed to be in a state of mild undress - similar to Kyle. Others were wiping off blades or retrieving arrows from the myriad corpses. And there were a *lot* of corpses. The Seafarers were stacking several as they policed them for weapons and trinkets.

"Glad you could join us!" came a rumbling voice. Catra twisted in the saddle and stared at the figure of Duncan as he approached from a small knot of Seafarers. She noticed that a couple were on the ground, covered in bandages; one had a cloth covering their whole body - clearly the fight hadn't been one sided. Just *mostly* one sided.

"Sir Duncan. WHy are your troops not in the fray?"

The elder Seafarer glanced down into the valley and snorted, "What, and ruin Adora's fun? I have learned my lesson. Let Teela compete. She needs to learn where she stands. No, we earned our mead today with this lot. Broke like rotten timber before us."

"You lost some?" Catra's query was tentative, surprised at his joviality. Duncan nodded slowly.

“A ye. Friks, may the moon watch over him in the hunt-eternal. Felled with honour, though. Four spears it took! And he made them pay for it.”

“The battle... how long?...

“We fell upon them a few hours ago. Adora did not wish to wait once we learned of them. The risk of them taking the village was too high - I am sad to say their scouts had managed to seize some villagers. We... hope they are in the main camp below.”

“Then why are you not *down* there?” Catra huffed. Duncan gave her a patient shrug.

“We will be called if needed. Adora bade we rest, recuperate for a second charge. To commit all our forces at once would be folly. And in case of flanking maneuvers by our foe. There is at least one additional hunting party afield that we're tracking.”

Catra watched the man as he adjusted his armour. She noticed there were sentries out, that the troops weren't *laing* about. She nodded curtly, then gestured to Pan, “Liaise with Duncan here. Get our people helping. I need to see what is going on.”

Duncan glanced at the cohort of Halfmoon troops and frowned, "Why have you brought the ghoul. There is danger in doing so."

"What, and leave her back at camp? Out of my sight? No. I can't imagine she'd manage much now. We've warded her and Sparkles is on her way with her guards, they're checking for more outliers."

"There be none," rumbled Duncan, his gaze fixed on the hunched figure of Shadow Weaver, "But bringing a Witch so close to death..."

Catra glanced at Pan, who seemed to be more alert now that there was the chance of real combat, "Keep a weather eye."

She moved the horse forwards to the edge of the rise, whilst Duncan beckoned several of his own men over to watch the shackled witch. Before the Princess, the ground dropped steeply down into the valley, with a narrow path leading down to the hamlet below. Watching, she could make out the battle below. It was more of a skirmish, really - the Horde not really keeping camps in the normal sense.

There was a solid number of Horde troops - their rotting bodies a mix of well-armoured foes and the "conscripts" - bewitched or risen troops clad in anything from rags to rotting leather. A great number littered the ground, as dismembered as those in Thaymor.

Catra squinted, her enhanced eyesight somewhat muted by the curse of the sun;she could make out the battle - a half-dozen Seafarers locked in combat. All fought in pairs, each one covering the other, moving in a way akin to a dance. She caught sight of a shock of red hair that could only be Teela, the woman moving with a brutal efficiency.

For a moment Catra could only think of the blade-dancers. A troupe of Halfmoon performers, their style supposedly based upon an ancient Magicat martial art. The style of combat was all dodges and balletic leaps;slices and momentum. Of course, in practice it was a style that would get you killed - no one fought like that in a brawl.

The reason she thought of it was because in the dance every movement was made with intent - to thread it to another one, to move in sync in a whirlwind of steel and flexibility .

This was *similar* . Except it was solid and brutal. No clever weaves here, no subtle dodges. The fighters moved in tandem, blocking, covering, absorbing blows and driving their foes back. Teela fought with a stave, back to back with the rangey man she fought alongside. He wielded a buckler and blade, guarding her flank and hacking at any who got too close, bashing them back with the shield rim, doing more damage with that than the nasty sword he held.

As Catra watched, her concern grew - she couldnt find Adora in the melee. Her anxiety gnawed at her . Had the woman fallen, among the dead?W as Teela now fighting a rear guard?

Almost unconsciously, Catra slid from her horse, eyes fixed on the battle below - it wasnt far - a short sprint and she would be in the thick of it - twenty, thirty seconds perhaps. She glanced across the field of battle, her view obscured by some of the houses. The Horde numbered in the dozens, some stumbling from within houses, others trying to push in against the fighters she could see.

And then the window of one house collapsed outwards, wood splintering as a huge, armoured figure fell backwards through the boarding that had been put in place.

Catra sagged with strange relief as she saw Adora. The blonde was atop the bulky form of her opponent, sword planted deep into the thing's chest. As Catra watched, the blonde stood and twisted the blade, then wrenched it free. With a contemptuous swing, the towering warrior swept the head from the downed foe's shoulders, then turned to face the incoming wave of opponents. Catra's eyes widened as a swarm rushed the warrior.

And Adora *laughed* . Catra could just about hear it on the wind. It was a sound of unbridled glee.

The blonde surged forwards. She met the horde with her sword swinging.

Again Catra thought back on the court - not the blade dancers, but rather her fencing instructors. She knew the reality of the arming sword, how it was to be used - not just as a blade, but as a tool.

Compared to how a rapier was seen as just a cut and thrust weapon, a proper sword as a sharp quarterstaff, really.

And Adora *showed* that. She used the blade like a bar, a club. She swung and beheaded one foe, the followed up the swing with a shoulder barge. Then she brought the blade up in an uppercut that *bisected* an enemy. The blade arced, came down and stuck in another opponent. Adora kicked the body and wrenched the blade free, then turned and gripped the blade and haft to hold it like a staff. She used the blade to shove a pair of attackers back, then pivoted and rammet the point into the skull of *another* attacker. As she pulled it back she didnt waste time trying to turn the blade to the opponent behind her. Instead she just moved her shoulders and jabbed the pommel of the sword into that attacker's head, caving in the skull.

She swung the balde, where it suddenly caught in the gut of a larger foe. Catra watched, shocked, as Adora cursed, then released the blade to deliver a sickening punch to the undead soldier's face.

The hit smashed the thing's jaw off and sent it reeling. Adora turned, unarmed and grappled another attacker. She yanked at him, just as another foe lunged and grappled at her from behind.

Catra gasped and broke into a run. She barely registered Duncan's bemused smile, while he just stood there, arms crossed, as if nothing were amiss.

Catra dropped to all fours, pounding down the steep slope. Her mind was full of images of blue eyes. Blue eyes she desperately wanted to look into again. All she could see ahead was the swarm piling onto Adora, around Adora as she punched and kicked. She idly registered that Adora seemed to be hitting the undead with something - it looked like an arm?

And the the blonde sunk out of view as the tide overwhelmed her.

"Adora!" Catra practically yelled the name as she barreled towards the fight. One of the undead at the fringes turned, sightless, milky white eyes fixed onto her. Catra leapt, bounced off the wall of a nearby hut and came down *hard* on the zombie, sword out. The blade cleaved into the soldier's skull, smashing it easily.

She turned towards the pile and readied her weapon, then dashed forwards. She sliced the leg from a foe before her, then moved to sever the head from another. Some turned towards her, but she leapt up and practically vaulted over them, claws out to rip apart exposed flesh and tear at limbs. Her attacks were clean and quick - she left the Horde soldiers without limbs or with heads hanging by a thread as she pushed towards the wrestling mob that held Adora... *her Adora*.

The thought stopped her in her tracks for the barest second, but she pushed on - she could tackle that later.

She closed in - it looked like the pile on wasn't actually a pile on; that perhaps Adora was somehow holding them back. And then, just as she got within a few yards, she was forced to stagger back as the throng practically exploded outwards, bodies tumbling as something arose from the scrum.

Catra stared at the vision before her.

The creature towered at eight feet tall - gold-white fur covered it, cresting into a mane. Arms rippled with muscle, while a canine-snout bared razor fangs in a snarl of glorious, focused threat. The beast held a Horde soldier in each hand, their forms limp like rag dolls. With a contemptuous snarl, the creature bit down on the head of one and tore the skull clean off from the body. Then it smashed the corpse into the slowly rising form of another Horde soldier. The impact crushed both frames and spattered gore across the hamlet's cobbled square.

The second body the beast ripped in two and flung to the floor. Then it set about absolutely *wrecking* the few remaining zombies. Catra stared and then let out a gasp as the beast turned towards her. Blue eyes found her and she could help but stare back.

"Beautiful," Catra's voice was a whisper. Awe, amazement and… something else, much more basic, thrummed within her. Blue eyes stared back. She knew them. Had known them as soon as she'd seen them on the beach the prior night.

Then Adora (For it had to be Adora) snarled and leapt forwards. Catra yelped surprise and brought her blade up. It sunk home, deep into Adora's gut as the wolf smashed into her…

And scooped her up with one arm?

Catra fumbled and shouted in protest. She heard a crunch and turned her head to stare up from her cradled position. She blinked in surprise as Adora hefted a black-armoured figure up, one handed, her fist gripping its armoured helm.

One of the Horde Commanders, it seemed. And he had been *behind* Catra?

As she watched, Adora *sqeezed* . There was the sound of metal crumpling while the Commander beat fruitlessly at the thick muscle of the beast's forearm. The flailing increased until, with a sudden spasm, Adora's fist closed with a wet sqelch. Then the Commander fell limp.

Adora gently set Catra down and then reached up to carefully, bizarrely so, pull the remnants of the Commander 's head from the bloodied mess of its body. Then she tossed the corpse across the field.

Around them the battle seemed to be faltering - without the commander, the Horde troops seemed to lose any cohesive drive,

becoming near feral and disjointed. Their movements were not that of directed automata, but now the slumping, lurching movements of unguided, mindless *things* .

"You rob us of our honourable kills! You cannot claim *all* of them!" came a cry of mock outrage. Catra, still stunned, turned on tottering legs to find a blook-soaked Teela and her combat-partner striding forwards. Around them, the other four Seafarers were making short work of the remaining Horde. Teela noticed Catra and her smile broadened, "Ah you did catch us up and..ohhhh."

Her eyes dropped to the sword in Adora's gut. Teela's eyebrow raised but her smile didnt fade. If anything it became a broader smirk.

Catra inhaled unsteadily and turned to Adora. She watched the she-wolf as she stood at her full height. A clawed hand reached down and pulled at the blade sunk into her flesh. Catra stared, aghast, as the blade came free. Then she blinked as the wound began to knit closed. It was slow, though and she watched as Adora turned her huge head from side to side, studying the blade.

"Um..we, uh..we use silver and magic infusions? Cuts..cuts the bodies better. And, um, silver kills infections? And um, other beings like..us? I guess?" She clasped her upper arm with one hand and gave a half shrug with a thin smile.

Adora made a noise that sounded part chuff, part laugh, part disgruntled groan. Teela sniggered. Catra just stared as she watched a werewolf, an actual *werewolf* roll its eyes.

Then Adora fixed her with a stare and squatted down, so she was eye level with Catra. She cocked her head from one side to the other, then chuffed. The beast stood, then loped across the hamlet to where something was sticking out of a corpse. Catra realised it was Adora's sword. She watched, confused, as the werewolf levered the blade out from the corpse. Then the great creature turned and lumbered back, surprisingly graceful given her size.

Adora paused, then drove Catra's sword into the ground next to her . Then she squatted down again and of fered Catra her own blade, pommel first. Catra's eyes slid to her sword, the one she'd stabbed Adora with, planted in the soil. She frowned, then looked at the blade being offered to her.

It was huge. Not impractically so, of course, but not one she was familiar with. But it had a brutal elegance to it - simple in its design and purpose. Tentatively she reached out and trailed a clawed hand down the blood-stained blade. She glanced up and found Adora's eyes watching her, studying her. She could get lost in that gaze, she realised.

She wanted to get lost in it.

Carefully, slowly, she gripped the haft of the sword. Adora released her grip on the blade and Catra almost stumbled at the weight. She recovered, her natural strength meaning she could wield it fairly well. She raised it up and studied the metalwork, then looked at Adora.

The werewolf reached down and plucked Catra's sword from the soil, then hefted it up. Adora flung her head back and *howled* .

Teela picked up the cry, followed by the other Seafarers around them, then by those up on the hill. Catra noticed several of her own troops making their way down, clearly in a rush to help her, but now pausing, confused.

The feeling was surreal, Catra couldnt help but let out a breathy laugh. She shook her head, then leaned her own head back and exalted with a howl of her own.

A moment later she lolled her head forwards and found the Seafarers looking at her with.approval?T eela looked exasperated but also oddly happy?Adora…

Adora was human again.

And naked.

And grinning like an absolute giddy loon.

Before Catra could even speak the naked warrior had scooped her up and flung her over her shoulder. The Princess hissed and flailed then yelped in surprise as Adora broke into a *sprint* up the hill. The very steep hill. Which she seemed to scale with no real issue. Teela kept pace, moving with an easy lope that made it seem they *hadn't* just been fighting an entire horde of the undead.

At the top of the hill Adora hefted Catra off her shoulder and spun, the magicat held aloft and twirled about as she hissed and flailed, "Put me down you..you *idiot*!"

Adora laughed and then gently placed Catra to the ground, then bounced on her feet, "This is a GOOD day!"

Catra had to blink at the image of a naked, bouncing Adora. Admittedly most of the woman was hard planes and defined muscle, but *still*. She averted her eyes and took a deep breath, then stared at where the woman *should* have had a stab wound.

There wasn't even a mark. Catra pointed, dumbly, "You..where's the wound?"

"Ah! Yes! Your silver blade was..painful, but still, I heal quickly! Not the way I would have chosen to proffer blades, but..well, I am so *happy*."

"Uh, ok.well, I.well count me impressed, ok?That was… impressive," Catra blew out a breath, then gestured at Adora, "Uh, dont you want, I dont know.some clothes"?

"I will collect it later . I think my armour is.a bit worse for wear currently. And anyway, we shall not need clothing for after the feast!"

Adora's excited grin made Catra suspicious. She felt she was missing something, "Feast"?

"To celebrate, of course!"

"I mean, yeah, great victory . And, well, you saved a whole village… oh gods the villagers!"

She turned back to the valley but Teela shook her head, "We found several..But most were gone. The survivors are being tended to by our people. THere are cages in the buildings. Fear not, they will be well."

Catra shook and sagged, then turned around, "Then we definitely owe a debt of thanks.and.well.we can discuss the terms of an alliance."

Adora cocked her head in confusion, as did Teela, "We have exchanged blades."

"Uh. Yeah"…

"Catra!" Glimmer's voice cut through the air as she descended, gossamer wings fluttering like mad, "No…hooo…other Horde parties…that, phew, we could find. Bow and his hunters are checking the wooooooaaaaah naked. Naked. VERY NAKED"

Glimmer's eyes glazed as she stared at Adora. Then she pivoted to raise an eyebrow at Catra. The Magicat gave an uncomfortable shrug, "So, uh…turns out they have a *reason* for being…kind of terrifyingly good at combat?"

"They fight naked? I mean…do the dead notice?" Glimmer looked thoroughly perplexed. And she kept shooting surreptitious glances at Adora, while biting her lip.

That made Catra *irritated*. She had a sudden urge to scratch Glimmer. She forced the thought down and looked to her troop. Her eyes narrowed as she saw Shadow Weaver, sitting bolt upright. The woman had her gaze fixed on the Magicat. Adora, watching Glimmer and Catra's exchange with bemusment, turned to follow Catra's gaze and froze.

A growl came from the warrior's throat, "Why is she here?"

The tone made Catra immediately take a step back. Not out of fear of *Adora* - but rather the tone of worry that underlaid the warrior's voice. Shadow Weaver's scarred face twisted into a sneer.

"What have you seen then, whelp? Did the monsters show their colours, reveal their abominable pact to you? Their half-blood state as *beasts* ? I thought you filth, but these *things* , these *monsters…* "

"You will not address my mate with such disrespectful tones, *hag* ," Adora intoned. The blonde moved slowly towards the horse. Catra noticed that the beast's eyes seemed dull. And it hadn't jinked or whinnied. In fact, it seemed oblivious to everything around it. No ear twitches. No huffing.

In fact.the horse wasn't even breathing.

"The horse," Catra hissed. Her brain was trying to tell her something else, but right now she could only take in the fact that Pan was next to Shadow Weaver, on his horse.

And he was bolt upright and still as well. Adora spread her arms.

"You felt the commander die," it wasn't a question.

"Indeed. An opportunity I could not miss."

Shadow Weaver flexed her arms and the shackles fell away. Catra gawped. Glimmer gasped and flourished her hands. A staff popped into existence, crackling with bright pink light. Shadow Weaver scoffed.

"Your paltry tricks will not aid you, you simpering buffoon. All this *death*, this *entropy* ... "

The witch raised a hand. Around the camp, the dead bodies jolted and began to dissolve into ash. The wounded began to shriek as their bodies convulsed, green energy pulsating around them. Catra hissed and brought Adora's blade up, ready. The blonde warrior herself crouched, ready to strike.

And then a spear tip slammed out of Shadow Weaver's chest.

The witch stuttered in shock and gurgled. Her horse wobbled, then collapsed. The wounded stopped convulsing and drew shuddering breaths. Pan groaned and fell from his horse, which also fell, dead-weight, almost atop him.

A shrieking figure sprinted across the camp, scrawny and blonde. It leapt forwards and landed atop Shadow Weaver and began raining blows down with vicious determination. The sound of bone and flesh

cracking and splattering filled the silent air, along with the gurgling wails of the witch.

He reached down and began to lever at the witch's head, his eyes wild. There was a crack, then a pop and he sat back on his haunches, then hefted Shadow Weaver's head up, torn from her shoulders.

Catra's jaw dropped. She slowly lowered the sword and stared, "He… *what*?"

Adora, for her part, sagged as well, then planted her hands on her hips, "Gods *dammit* Kyle. I wanted to end the hag. She insulted my wife!"

Glimmer froze and turned to stare at Catra, "Wife?"

Catra's own thoughts came to a tumbling stop, "*Wife*?"

Adora ignored them and strode to where Kyle sat. The shorter man grinned up at her, then proffered the head. Adora took it, holding the macabre trophy by the lank, black hair. She brought it up to eye level and scoffed, "You are fooling no one, witch. Speak your prattle or be cast into the fire along with the thralls."

Shadow Weaver's eyes fluttered open and she hissed, a keening noise. Her eyes looked about, distraught, "No...noo..." her words a gurgle as shredded vocal chords tried to talk, weeping magics animating their ruined threads.

"You venerated Kildor so...now you will be akin to him. Bag her up - no doubt my mate will wish to keep her. I shall not take what has not been as yet given."

Adora tossed the head to Duncan. Shadow Weaver wailed as she tumbled, then whimpered as the burly Duncan caught her with one hand, then shoved her into a burlap sack. Runes flared across its surface for the briefest moment. Adora then looked down at the fallen Pan. Several of Catra's other soldiers had rushed to his side as he'd fallen and he was being helped to his feet. The men stilled as the naked human accosted them, their ears twitching and tails lashing in agitation.

The blonde peered at the man, then down at the corded leash that had been attached the Shadow Weaver, "Teela, come look."

The red head approached, while Catra just gawped, overwhelmed. Too many things were happening and she felt buffeted. She watched as Teela studied the cord.

"Ah. The flow of the death magics...she was able to flood the runes and the connection to him. Enthralled him in his sun-drunk state."

"Interesting, is it not? A vulnerability."

That jolted the Princess, "What? WHAT? You seek our weaknesses?" she stalked over the grass, Glimmer skipping to keep up, "And...and what is… *wife*. I did not...and… *what*!?"

Adora regarded her with an expression of gentle care, "We are shield-mated. Bonded in battle. Exchanged of blades. We are as close as two can be. Of course we will not be mated until the feast and the ceremony under the moon, but I assure"…

"Hold on, HOLD the HELLS on. By the lives of my ancestors and all the god damned wine in my cellars. You...you said...right, you said you wanted to be mated to the greatest warrior and *highest* in our court. Well...well what if that isn't"…

"You?" Adora folded her arms and Catra had to fight the urge to glance down. And damn if she didn't have to fight. It was bad enough that Adora's throat was pulsing with the beat of her heart, that she could smell the sweat of the woman and wanted to do several things that were most certainly not suitable for the middle of a battlefield.

"Yes," seethed Catra, channeling her urges into anger instead.

"Are you not the first born daughter of Cyra? Princess of Halfmoon? Renowned warrior, tactician and scourge of the Horde? Bulwark of the Hinterlands? The Shadow that Strikes?"

Catra raised a finger and her mouth opened. She squinted, then dropped her hand, "Uh," she glanced at Glimmer who raised her own hands.

"I didn't say a damn thing."

The magicat turned back to Adora, "How'd you know?"

"Well, one, Razz told me," Adora lifted one hand, elbow cupped in her other and listed on her fingers, "Two, a magicat delegation in search of allies would likely send a trusted member of the court. We know your are...reclusive. You would wish to minimise contact. And lessen the chains that could be compromised. Risk and reward, your race leads from the front. We know this," she nodded and raised a third finger, "And three... I know you, Catra. As I know my own soul. You are my *sjelevenn.* That which completes me."

The way Adora said that last, with such conviction, such utter belief, rocked Catra. Those blue eyes, eyes that had haunted her dreams, bored into her. It quenched the anger like the ocean would a campfire.

Adora took a step forwards and cupped her hand to Catra's cheek. The Princess swallowed and tried to muster her frustration once more, "But...you know our weakness."...

"One must know an allies strengths and their flaws. How best can I protect you, if I do not know where you might falter? When I need to stand watch while you lay your head down. And you will come to know mine. How can I protect my new people, if I do not know what they fear in the dark? How best can I aid you in combat if I know not where your blade should slide, where it should strike. We are battle-bonded, blood-wed. You feel it. You may not wish it, yet, I can see that."

Adora's eyes looked sad for a moment, but she stepped back, her hand falling away from Catra's face. The Magicat reached up and touched her cheek, suddenly upset at the loss. She searched Adora's face, "Battle…battle-bonded?"

"We fought. We slaid enemies. Watched each other's flanks. Teela and her fellows, they are battle-wed, but not mated. They compliment one another. But she will not go beyond such intimacy, for her true sword partner is Adam. Should you wish it…I can." Adora looked away, "I can accept that may be all we are. Wed in sword, bonded by blood. And once this war is done, we shall quit these shores and I will tear my soul away."

Catra studied her, then looked at Glimmer. The fairy had a very confused look on her face. She met Catra's gaze then gestured at Adora.

"A of Adora.

The look she gave Catra was one of near-incredulity and she leaned in, "If you do not snatch this up, by my Mother 's eternal reign I will leave Bow and lock her in my own bedchambers."

And that sent a righteous growl from Catra's throat. Glimmer leaned back and grinned. The Magicat turned to look at Adora once more. The warrior looked, for the first time, vulnerable. Yes, naked, but vulnerable in a different way. She still stood, unashamed, but uncertain.

"So...we'd be married...as, basically a skirmishing band? Sisters in arms?"

"Y es."

"All because we...fought together?"

"And...because we gave each other our swords."

"Adora, I *stabbed you* . By *mistake* ."

Adora's grin was lopsided and she shrugged, "Thought I'd take a chance."

Catra blinked, then chuckled. It morphed into a full on cackle, a squeaking laugh that made her clutch her sides. She wiped her tears away and surveyed the blonde warrior. She folded her own arms and cocked her head back.

She knew, in her soul, deep down, that this was *her* . Her person. Her other half. The aura the woman exuded, the confidence, the tenderness and downright *decency* she had. The woman had rushed out here to save villagers she didn't know . Yes, it was to get an alliance;but it was an alliance these Seafarers didn't *need* . Adora could've ridden out with them today and fought the monsters in the field.

But no. They'd run off to tackle the problem.

From a pragmatic point of view, her people *needed* these warriors. Two hundred or more Horde soldiers vanquished, along with a Necromancer commander. All for *one* Seafarer death? And a village spared.

From a purely *base* point of view, she took in Adora's self - the chiseled frame, her bearing, her frankly stunning and handsome features. She was, to put it bluntly, amazing.

But at the core, Catra realised, she wanted to *know* this woman. To learn about her. To grow with her. That rush to join in combat with her, that window into *more* that she offered. That was the truth of it.

Catra made a show of mulling things over, "And…and if, say…I…was open to…more"…

Adora's eyes widened a little and she nodded, "If"…

"What would that, erm…entail"?

Adora's eager grin shifted to a more cocky expression. The same one from the night prior. She leaned forwards, "Well, we have a bonding ritual. Under the moon, we pledge ourselves. Body and soul. There's a feast," she waved her hand dismissively, "But the couple are not expected to attend for long. I am sure I could find you something to…drink"?

Catra watched as Adora looked up innocently and tapped thoughtfully at her throat. The magicat swallowed, "Oh"?

"Yes. As you can tell, I run hot, though. So I would probably need something to eat…" and Catra shivered as those blue eyes locked back onto her.

"So, in summary…I…would be married to you."

"More so than you are now, yes. Or the same, if you accept now, of course. It's…flexible."

"And I would have your swords, your soldiers?"

"Yes."

"But I would have them anyway *without* being married?"

"Yes."

"Honestly that option sounds super dull."

Adora grinned, "It does, yes."

"What do you get out of all of this?" Catra's eyes narrowed.

"You were not listening. For a woman with such lovely ears, you do not hear well," Adora teased, "I get *you*. If you are willing, of course."

"Me."

"Yes."

Catra bit her lip and eyed Adora, "And I get you?"

"Yes."

Catra's grin broadened. She thought of what awaited back at Halfmoon; the likely repercussions and shockwaves; the decisions on how to approach the Horde, how to factor in this mysterious race from across the Sea - these people who could become glorious, monstrous, gorgeous *beasts*.

She wondered how her mother would react; had a feeling she knew. She eyed Adora, then stalked towards her, tail lashing from side to side. She fixed her gold-and-blue eyes on the blue before her.

"You know? I really, *really* like the sound of *that*."

Chapter End Notes

Ok. Leaving you hanging. And MORE world building.

Because, yknow what, I feel this could grow into a series! Maybe some little stories to expand the world and to follow these two crazy fools, these soul mates, these clearly horny-on-main monsters...

End Notes

A one shot for now, to maybe lay the ground work for SOMETHING else. If I do, itll be a quick three chapter one, because I dont think anyone wants ANOTHER live by the sword / Grace and Favour journey just yet ;)

Mostly, I had the idea for VAMPIRE CAT and VIKING ADORA (maybe something more...) and wanted to write out their first meeting.

Throw in some FATE. And well, here we are!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!